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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT SUMMONS HOUSE SESSION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

President Ramchandra Paudel has summoned the winter session of both the House of Representatives and the National Assembly for 4 pm on February 5.

As per a statement issued by the President's Office, the summon was made on the recommendation of the Council of Ministers.

The previous budget session of the parliament had concluded on November 2, 2023.

PM: EVERYONE HAS SHARED ROLE IN NATION BUILDING

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government, political parties and people from all backgrounds and levels are responsible for building the nation.

He said that the nation needed political, economic, social, cultural and educational transformation and asked everyone to take responsibility for bringing about this transformation.

The Prime Minister said that the state needed to give people hope for a better tomorrow and asked eminent persons to support this endeavour.

Meeting with intellectuals, including Dr. Kedar Bhakta Mathema, Dr. Pitambar Sharma, Dr. Bidyanath Koirala, Dr. Chaitanya Mishra and Professor Krishna Khanal, at his official residence in Baluwatar on Wednesday, PM Prachanda said that he always felt the need to bring the best brains together to advance the nation.

He also said that he was committed to ending political Bhagbanda at universities and asked the personalities to help.

Stating that he has continuously been working for good governance, social justice and prosperity, the Prime Minister said that the state needed to give people hope for a better tomorrow and asked eminent persons to support this endeavour.

The gathered academicians welcomed the PM's initiative to end partisan appointments at universities and choose the next vice chancellor of the Tribhuvan University on the basis of merit. Further, they asked him to restructure the entire education sector to push reform.



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Sepukhola village of Barekot Rural Municipality-8 in Jajarkot district.

Sagarmatha Lokmarga in sorry state due to negligence of contractor

BY RAJKUMAR BHATTARAI
Khotang, Jan. 24

Three decades have passed since the construction of the Sagarmatha Lokmarga began, yet the blacktopping remains incomplete.

The then Prime Minister, Manamohan Adhikari, laid the foundation stone for the construction of the Sagarmatha Lokmarga (highway) in 1995.

Sanjib Kumar Mishra, head of the Gaighat-Diktel Road Office in Udayapur, said that even after three decades since the commencement of road construction, not even 30 km of the road has been paved. The delay in the construction is because of the contractor company, he added.

Contracts were awarded at different stages for the road from Gaighat to Diktel under the Lokmarga project. However, owing to the construction company's negligence, the road is now at a standstill. If the work had been done as agreed, it would be smooth. Now, it is slippery in the rain and dusty in winter, causing issues for vehicles, he informed.

The contract was given for two sections of the 49 km Mahure-Phoksingtar road in Khotang, under the Gaighat-Diktel section. The Udayapur-based Gaighat-Diktel road office said that the construction company has not fulfilled its obligations even three years after the contract expired. As a result, the process of reopening the tender has now begun, following the termination of the previous contract.

Debnarayan Pawan-Mainachuli-Khampache JV secured the contract for the Simpani Bhanjyang to Phoksingtar section, covering 27 km out of the two sections. The agreement, signed on July 26, 2016, mandated the completion of paving by July 25, 2020, for Rs. 558 million.

The contract was canceled in January 2022 as the physical progress was below 50 per cent even after the deadline. The construction company challenged the termination in the Patan High Court. After an interim order was issued in the initial hearing, the process of canceling the contract was halted.

Mishra informed that a few months ago, the court upheld the decision to terminate the contract after dismissing the contractor's writ. As a result, the process of reopening the tender has now been initiated.

After the office decided to terminate the contract, the construction company filed a writ in court and began blacktopping some parts of the road near Foksingtar Bridge. However, the road is currently in a derelict condition.

Similarly, Bharat Construction-Siddhi Shahi undertook the road paving task for the 22 km road from Mahure to Rajapani section at Rs. 415 million. The agreement, signed on July 14, 2016, stipulated completion by July 13, 2020.

Mishra said that the contract was terminated due to prolonged non-completion. The company has left the work in a crumbling condition since January 2023.

Mishra explained that the contract was terminated when blacktop work did not commence even three and a half years beyond the deadline. He said that they asked the Department of Road to terminate the contract last October, but the department officially terminated it just a week ago.

Mishra informed that both contracts for the road section towards Udayapur have been terminated. Following the termination, the process of reopening the tender for the Mahure-Foksingtar road section has been initiated.

"The estimates have been prepared, and the file has been forwarded to the department. If there is an agreement to utilise the existing savings, a new tender will be called," he added.

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PHOTO: RAJKUMAR BHATTARAI/TRN

A bridge constructed over Sunkoshi River of Sagarmatha Lokmarga.

'Govt will table more Bills in winter session of House'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the government has prioritised tabling and passing as many bills as possible in the winter session to give continuous business to the federal parliament.

Minister Sharma, speaking at a press conference organised to make the Cabinet decisions public at the Ministry on Wednesday, said that the Ministry of Law has been holding separate meetings with the concerned ministries to table necessary bills from the respective ministries in the federal parliament.

Currently, most of the ministries are engaged in producing necessary bills after the instruction of the Prime Minister, Minister Sharma said.

Minister Sharma said that important laws such as the Federal Education Act, the Federal Civil Service Act and the Police Act will also be finalised from the upcoming session of the House

"All ministries, including communications, will take the bills. The government hopes that this session will really turn into a bills session and, homework is being done accordingly," Minister Sharma said.

The government will take forward other necessary bills in the upcoming winter session of the federal parliament scheduled for February 5 to make the session really a session of bill presentation, Minister Sharma said.

Similarly, Minister Sharma said that the government will settle the issue of dedicated and trunk line of several industries and factories as per the recommendation made by the 3-member probe committee headed by former judge Girish Chandra Lal.

The government is not in a mood to exempt the dues to be raised from such industries after consuming the electricity, Minister Sharma said.

Meanwhile, the Cabinet held on January 23 has decided to transfer third tranche of financial equilization grants to the respective province and local levels as per revenue ratio collected as of January 14 of the current fiscal and the last tranche after the collection of revenue till mid-April, 2024.

CABINET DECISIONS

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting upon the proposal of the Ministry of Home Affairs has given authority in principle to draft a bill related to the Armed Police Force Nepal.

The government has formed a committee to investigate the election dispute of the International Coordination Council of the Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA).

According to the government spokesperson Sharma, the committee was formed under the coordination of Dhruva Kumar Chauhan, Deputy Attorney General of the Attorney General's Office.

The members of the committee are Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Senior Superintendent of Police and Under Secretary. The committee has been given a deadline of 15 days.

Similarly, the government has formed a three-member study committee under the coordination of Chintamani Siwakoti, former deputy governor of Nepal Rastra Bank, to conduct a study on organised institutions that operate the securities market.

The government has approved the resignation tendered by Honorary Consulate General of New South Wales

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National Assembly election today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Election to the National Assembly is being held on Thursday. Voters have reached the provincial capitals of all seven provinces to cast their votes.

Altogether 549 members of the provincial assemblies and 1,498 chiefs and deputy chiefs of local levels will cast their votes to elect 19 members of the Upper House of the Federal Parliament.

Term of the 20 of the 59 members of the National Assembly is expiring in March this year, and 19 of them will be elected on Thursday while the remaining one will be nominated by the President. The Election Commission said that preparations and security arrangements for the poll were completed in all polling stations.

Altogether 51 candidates from eight political parties are contesting the election. According to the Election Commission, voting will take place from 9 am to 3 pm at designated voting centres across the country.

Members of the National Assembly serve six-year terms with one-third of the total members retiring every two years.



PHOTO: RSS

An NA polling booth in Dang.

CIAA arrests suspended Nepal Telecom officials

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Nepal Telecom's former Managing Director (currently suspended) Sunil Paudel and Security Printing Centre (SPC)'s Executive Director (currently suspended) Bikal Paudel were arrested on Wednesday.

Issuing a press statement, the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) informed that a CIAA team had arrested Sunil and Bikal on Wednesday after both were found having acquired illegal assets.

According to the CIAA, during investigation on Sunil and Bikal, it was revealed that both had opened foreign currency accounts in foreign banks without the approval of the Nepal Rastra Bank, deposited money and received formal appointments in international advisory positions while being actively employed in government service of Nepal.

Additionally, Bikal was found to have obtained a permanent residency permit in the United States.

The CIAA informed that the accused were detained for further investigation considering the possibility of tampering with evidence and fleeing.

Meanwhile, the CIAA has filed a corruption case against eight officials of Udayapur Cement Factory including its former General Manager Surendra Kumar Paudel at the Special Court, Kathmandu on Wednesday.

According to the CIAA, Udayapur Cement Factory's Deputy General Manager Nawal Kishor Sah, former deputy director Pawan Kuman Lal Karna, former managers Bharat Prasad Nepal and Kamal Raj Paudel, officer Dem Lal Khanal and former directors Prof. Dhurba Bahadur Devkota and Mahesh Prasad Kafle including Paudel had purchased and made payments contrary to the Procurement Act when there was no need and justification from a technical point of view.

The CIAA informed that the defendants purchased items without conducting research and maintaining quality standards which also included a purchase of 160 KW VFD

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Rescued snow leopard cub brought to Central Zoo

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

An injured snow leopard cub, rescued from Morang, was brought to the Central Zoo in Lalitpur on Wednesday.

The young wild cat was found in Charghare of Urlabari Municipality-1 in Morang district on Tuesday.

The snow leopard was discovered hiding in the bamboo forest. Upon receiving reports from locals, they alerted the police and the Division Forest Office in Morang. However, initial attempts to rescue the leopard were unsuccessful. Subsequently, the Division Forest Office sought assistance from a team of the Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve and the National Trust for Nature Conservation. This team, comprised of five skilled individuals, including a veterinarian and technicians, successfully captured and brought the snow leopard under control using darting.

Director General of the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation, Dr. Sindhu Prasad Dhungana, said that the rescued snow leopard of two to three years old has been brought to the Central Zoo for treatment on Wednesday morning. The animal was found to have an injury in its front leg.



Since snow leopards require cold temperatures, treating it in the Koshi Tappu might not be suitable, as the Central Zoo is more suitable than the Tarai. The snow leopard has been placed in the safest room with a controlled temperature. It will stay there until the completion of the treatment, and afterward, it will be released back into the wild, Dr. Dhungana confirmed.

However, it has raised concerns as to how the snow leopard, typically found at elevations of 2500 metres and above from sea level, was spotted in the Tarai lowland at 150 metres.

According to conservation scientist Dr. Madhu Chhetri, the snow leopard might have descended in the wrong direction after being separated from its mother. Typically, carnivores establish their territories after parting ways from their mothers, and in this instance, it is possible that it unintentionally moved down towards human habitats due to the connecting territory.

This is a rare occurrence of discovering high-elevation animals in lowland areas. However, similar cases have been reported in Mongolia and Russia, where snow leopards and Himalayan wolves were also recorded in lowland regions at about 500 metres.

"While discussing the impact of climate change, it should have moved to higher elevations if that were the cause. However, finding a young snow leopard in the lowlands is not attributed to climate change. Trafficking is also ruled out as a cause since it is a large carnivorous animal and cannot be easily transported," he informed.

According to Chhetri, the mating period for the mother typically begins when the cub reaches 24 months old, leading to their separation. During this separation, the cub ventures out to find its own territory. Considering the proximity of Kanchenjunga above Morang, known as a suitable habitat for snow leopards, it is plausible that the animal might have descended from that area due to confusion.

Birendra Gautam, Chief of the Koshi Conservation Centre at the National Trust for Nature Conservation, said that during the rescue, the snow leopard displayed aggressive behavior and sustained injuries. He added that locals might have unintentionally harmed it while attempting to chase it away.

The snow leopard was sent to the Central Zoo at 9:30 pm on Tuesday after being rescued and initially brought to the Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve.

Land acquisition process for Lower Arun Hydropower Project begins

BY DHYAN KULUNG
Sankhuwasabha, Jan. 24

The land acquisition process for the 669-MW Lower Arun Hydropower Project, to be built in the district, has started. The process of acquisition has started with the publication of the details of the land to be acquired in the Gorkhapatra daily.

The Sutlej Jalvidyut Nigam, which is constructing the project, needs 65 hectares of land for this hydroelectricity project. Coordinator of the committee formed for the determination of compensation for the land and Chief District Officer Shiva Kumar Karki informed that the land required for the project was identified and a public notice was published.

He informed that after the study of the project by the compensation determination committee, a notice was published for the acquisition of 565 plots of land within the two municipalities.

According to the information published in the notice, the concerned landowners have to submit their claims and objections to the committee within a week. CDO Karki informed that if the land owners do not register any protest or complaint in the compensation determination committee, the process of acquisition would begin immediately.

After this, the committee will determine the value of the land. Assistant Chief District Officer Mohan Mani Ghimire informed that there are some bases for determining the compensation rate of the land to be acquired.



PHOTO: DHYAN KULUNG/TRN

Lower Arun Hydropower Project is acquiring some 565 plots of land within two municipalities in Sankhuwasabha.

He informed that the price will be determined by looking at the latest price series of land, consumption of land, production, productivity, location, road access and the nature of the land.

He said that the value of roadside (household land) is the highest while land producing large cardamom, Rudraksha is of medium value and the rest of the land is of the lowest value. The project will give at least Rs. 875,000 to Rs. 1.175 million to a ropani of land.

Arun Dhiman, Chief Executive Officer of Nigam, informed that the land acquisition required for this project would be completed within two or three months.

He said that after the acquisition of the land, the contract for the construction work will be awarded and the project will be completed within seven years from the contract date.

The dam of the project will be located in Ward No. 2 of Chichila Rural Municipality while the power house will be constructed in Chewa Benshi of Khandbari Municipality-2. The cost of the project is estimated at Rs. 92.68 billion.

BUDGET CRUNCH HITS DRINKING WATER PROJECTS

RSS
Godavari (Kailali), Jan. 24

The drinking water projects operated in Kailali have been hit hard due to budget crunch. According to the Drinking Water and Sanitation Division Office, Dhangadhi, over two dozen drinking water projects that were initiated in Kailali since 2007 have been facing uncertainty due to budget crisis.

The office said the federal government has not allocated necessary budget for the completion of the project.

Although some of the projects being run in Kailali have developed physical structures, installing pipes has not been completed due to lack of necessary budget. It is said that the projects having physical infrastructure could not come into operation due to lack of budget.

Acting chief of the Drinking Water and Sanitation Division Office, Kailali, Ganesh Prasad Upadhyay, said over two dozen projects have been in limbo due to the government's ignorance in allocating budget required for the completion of the project.

According to him, allocation of peanut budget annually for the projects worth Rs 100 million will take years to complete the projects.

According to the office data, drinking water projects in Tikapur, Gauriganga, Lamkichuha municipality, Dhangadhi sub-metropolis, Janaki, Joshipur, Kailari and Bardagoria rural municipalities of Kailali have not been completed for the last 15 years.

Jhapa solar plant aiming to attract tourists



PHOTO:BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN

Jhapa Energy Limited's solar power plant in Bolochowk, Shivasatakshi Municipality-4 as seen in the picture. They are going to generate electricity to attract tourists.

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 24

Jhapa Energy Limited's solar power plant in Bolochowk, Shivasatakshi Municipality-4, is going to both generate electricity and attract tourists. The plant will be formally inaugurated on February 6 by CPN-UML Chairman and former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli.

According LP Sawa Limbu, member of the House of Representatives and chairman of Jhapa Energy, the plant has the capacity to produce 12 megawatts and the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has started purchasing 10 megawatts from it at a cost of Rs. 7.30 per unit.

Limbu hoped the project would link energy with tourism. "We are working to turn this plant into a solar park that lures visitors," he said, adding that they planned to plant flowers, build resorts and fun parks and construct sports related infrastructure to bring people from inside and outside the country. "We are also building a view tower," Limbu informed.

The solar plant covers an area of 21 Bighas and was set up with an investment of Rs. 810 million. Of this amount, 75 per cent was provided by financial institutions while 25 per cent was put in by locals, Narayan Prasad Pokharel, project chief of Jhapa Energy told The Rising Nepal.

Pokharel also informed that the Jhapa Energy and the NEA signed an agreement to purchase power on November 28, 2021.

NCELL LUX NUMBER ON GALAXY S24 PRE-BOOK

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

With the announcement of pre-order of Galaxy S24 series smartphones, Ncell is offering attractive bundling services and special facilities to Ncell users.

Under the partnership, the first 500 customers who pre-book the Samsung Galaxy S24 Series will get Ncell special LUX number as per their choice, the company said in a statement on Wednesday.

Samsung Nepal on Friday started taking pre-orders for the Galaxy S24 Series. Apart from premium Ncell numbers, customers who pre-order this smartphone receive 70 minutes all net voice, 700 MB data, and 70 SMS every day for free for a period of six months.

Umair Mohsin, chief Commercial Officer of Ncell said, "Galaxy S24 Series is all the more special as we are offering Ncell premium number on pre-orders. We are excited to partner with the leading global tech company committed to innovation and cutting-edge technology opening new possibilities."

The Galaxy AI in the series offers varied on-device experiences such as AI Live Translate in call and in person, Circle to search for better search results, Note Assist and Transcript Assist that makes everyday life much simpler.

These features ensure advanced security, privacy and the device is the strongest ever with Titanium build.

Immigration Department issues new travel advisory for visit-visa

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 24

The Department of Immigration, under the Ministry of Home Affairs, has recently issued a 13-point travel advisory along with a six-point procedure for individuals travelling abroad on visit and tourist visas. The issuance of the travel advisory was prompted by increasing reports of Nepali citizens falling prey to fraudulent activities while traveling on visit visas.

According to the Director and Information Officer of the Department, Prem Prasad Dahal, the newly introduced advisory and procedures are effective from today. The advisory explicitly states that seeking employment abroad while holding a visit or tourist visa is illegal. Engaging in such activities may lead to legal repercussions in the host country and cause various complications.

The advisory also clarifies that individuals are personally accountable for any consequences resulting from the submission of forged documents, providing false information, visiting a country not permitted by the visa, entering conflict zones, or joining foreign armed or military forces while abroad on a tourist or visit visa.

Likewise, the department has issued a cautionary note regarding the susceptibility of women to be tempted by intermediaries into traveling to labor destination countries such as Kuwait, Oman, the United Arab Emirates, and Bahrain on visit visa, persuading them to convert their visas into working ones, charging exorbitant fees and coercing them into precarious and indent labor conditions in collaboration with employers.

The Department has urged one and all to not pursue a foreign travel on the visit visa with the aim of working as it may push once into unorganized and precarious jobs, depriving of social security. It has encouraged citizens to seek a foreign job on just a working visa after obtaining a labour permit from the government.

Those Nepalis going to various countries on these visas have been urged to return to home country within the visa expiry date in other circumstances except for unusual conditions, as some Nepali travelers going to several countries on visit and tourist visa are found not returning on the stipulated date.

They have been asked to depart for foreign countries by making a self-declaration that they will return back home on the stipulated date since the person concerned would be responsible for any situation resulting from overstaying the visa. They have also been urged to set out on the visit after keeping general information regarding the language, culture and laws of the destination country.

"You might land in trouble if you work illegally in a foreign country going there after enrolling in a university listed with the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, but not studying in the university. Adopt additional precaution if you are visiting with the intention of enrolling in foreign university and working there through various middlepersons even when carrying study visa in the recent days, as study and work are separate matters," reads the travel advisory.

Those carrying visit and tourist visas have been requested to travel only via Nepal's airports, to do so only by taking the NOC Letter and, in the case of women, to adopt additional precaution and alert while travelling to third countries through airports in India.

People have been urged to ask for the authentic papers of the licensed institution before making the payment if any institution has sought money with the assurance of sending them to foreign country by taking labour permit. Similarly, people are advised to not give money if any education consultancy, travel agency or any person has asked for money with the assurance of sending on foreign employment.

People have been urged to inform the Department of Foreign Employment or the nearest police station or dial Nepal Police at 100, if they suspect that they are being conned.

People have been urged to only pay the minimum amount fixed by the government to the licensed institution sending them on foreign employment and take the receipt of the same, and not to believe in false assurances as there is no provision for agent.

The travel advisory states that getting recruited in the army or armed groups of any country is completely illegal and against the national interest, except in the case of the Indian Army and the British Army by taking approval from the Government of Nepal. People have been urged to not be involved in such activities under any circumstances as it is difficult to also rescue the people carrying out in such acts.

Traders demand scrapping of customs manual

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

The Nepal Foreign Trade Association (NFTA) has demanded the removal of the customs manual on valuation (database) used by the customs offices recently. "The manual has added challenges in the guidance of the World Trade Organization to recognise the transaction value, and has legitimised the misappropriation of foreign currency," President of NFTA, Binod Kumar Sethia said in an interaction organised by the Association on the occasion of the 72nd International Customs Day in Kathmandu on Tuesday evening.

He also emphasised on the stability of customs policy and leadership. "There is no indication of when the policy will be changed. Due to this, domestic and foreign investors are always suspicious. What kind of prosperity are we trying to achieve on the basis of political instability?" Sethia asked.

He demanded that the harmonic system code of 10 digits should be maintained for the classification of goods, and said that the practice of changing the classification for the purpose of collecting more tax should be brought to an end. Stating that high customs duty is promoting unauthorised trade, he suggested that customs should be levied on the unit of imported goods to reduce under-invoicing and to protect the domestic industry.

According to Sethia, if discounts are given on the air cargo while determining the customs duty of goods entering the country from air cargo, traffic will increase at the Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa and Pokhara International Airport.

He demanded that the import and export (EXIM) code number should be valid for five years, and the rules for canceling the EXIM code of companies that have stopped trading should be simple. He emphasized on the need to increase mutual trust between the government and the private sector to control the import and trade of duplicate goods.

Stating that import has decreased but revenue has increased recently, he said that when economic activity, industry, and trade increase, revenue increase will be sustainable and natural.

Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar, Secretary of the Ministry of Finance, expressed his commitment to solve the real problems raised by the NFTA immediately by discussing with the relevant agencies. Saying that businessmen also have problems, he advised businessmen to work honestly.

Dr. Pushkar also said that he is ready for the reforms in the law and technology upgrades.

Vice President of the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) suggested increasing the number of goods imported through the green channel of customs, reducing the time taken at the customs point, and implementing the system of trusted trader in various places including customs.

He said that the country should promote domestic production by discouraging the import of the goods that the country is self-reliant in has the potential to be self-sufficient.

Hemraj Dhakal, VP of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, emphasised the need to review the SAFTA and customs tariff rates. He also said that revenue should be increased by increasing business activities.

Director General of the Inland Revenue Department, Dirgha Raj Mainali, said that structural changes are taking place in the tax system. He said that he is always ready to listen to the problems and complaints of the tax sector and asked them to talk to him directly in case of any problem.

Director General of Customs Department, Shobhakant Paudel, said that the problem has arisen due to lack of clean and transparent trade.

Nepali's company to be listed in American stock exchange NASDAQ

RSS
Washington DC, Jan. 24

The Fusemachines Inc, a company set up by an entrepreneur of Nepali origin, Dr Sameer Maskey, is set to be listed in the US Stock Exchange-NASDAQ. The company recently entered into a definitive agreement for merger with CSLM Acquisition Corp, paving the path for the AI solutions provider enterprise to debut in the prestigious stock exchange NASDAQ.

Following the merger, the company's equity valuation is estimated to be worth USD 200 million, according to Dr Maskey, CEO of the Company. It will be publicly traded company on the NASDAQ under the name 'Fuse', said Dr Maskey, adding that deal for business combination with the CSLM Acquisition Corp is expected to be carried out at the end of second quarter of fiscal year 2024. The board members of the both companies have already approved the deal and it will be listed on NASDAQ following approval of stakeholders and fulfilling legal process.

Dr Maskey, who is also an Associate Professor at the Columbia University, established Fusemachines in 2013. Headquartered in New York of the USA, his company is currently operating across Nepal, Canada and USA. Of the total 450 employees working in the Fusemachines, 350 were Nepal and they were mostly outsourcing from Nepal, he said.

Talking to RSS, he said, "It is a significant milestone for the company to be listed in the NASDAQ and become a publicly traded company. I am confident that the company after partnership with the CSLM would make a leap in the sector of Artificial Intelligence in future."

Draft of integrated policy for Rautes still collecting dust

BY RAJANI YOGI
Surkhet, Jan. 24



PHOTO: TRN

A settlement of the nomadic Rautes in Dailekh. Two years have passed since the Karnali Province government announced to introduce an integrated policy to bring the Raute community to bring into the mainstream of the nation.

Two years have passed since the Karnali Province government announced to introduce an integrated policy to bring the Raute, who have been living a nomadic life in Dailekh and other districts into the mainstream of the nation.

The then Minister for Social Development of Karnali Province Yagya Bahadur Budhachhettri in a discussion held with stakeholders and experts on June 21, 2021, said a policy would immediately be formulated for Raute conservation. The Ministry also collected suggestions from the stakeholders. However, the policy-making process has not been completed yet.

The government then had said that an integrated policy would be formulated to protect the art, culture and originality of the Rautes and to ensure their safety and security after reports about the insecurity of the aboriginal people from the non-Raute community were surfaced.

Although a draft of the policy was prepared, other processes have not been moved forward. Anita Gyawali, Women Development Officer at the Ministry, said that the draft of the Raute conservation policy prepared around two years ago has been collecting dust at the Ministry.

Although the draft is being discussed in different phases, the policy has not been finalised. Issues such as providing permanent residences to the Rautes, distributing citizenship certificates to them and preserving their cultures by recording their language have been included in the draft policy.

However, the draft of the policy with a plan to distribute citizenship to Raute, who is living a nomadic life, has not been finalised for two years. After the death of 12-year child Durga Shahi on Thursday last week, the Raute community's population has come down to 137 at Bhairavi Rural Municipality-4. But after Durga's death, the Raute community has already shifted to Ward No 3 of Bhairavi Rural Municipality, said Lal Bahadur Khatri, a teacher working in the Raute settlement.

The Raute community has a tradition of relocating their settlement immediately after the death of any person in their settlement. In May/June this year, the population of the Raute was 142. Since then, nine people died and four children--three girls and a boy-- were born.

With the addition of the number of newborn babies, the population of the community is now 137. The community is at high risk due to excessive alcohol consumption, malnutrition and cold. The number of deaths due to excessive consumption of alcohol in the community is high.

Anuja Panta, a health worker at Raute Project, said that the health problems in the Raute community are also increasing with the increasing cold.

According to her, the women, children and elderly people in this community, who spend the night on the cold floor under wooden and cloth tents, are facing health problems. The Ministry of Social Development of the Province is going to conduct awareness programmes for the empowerment of the Raute community in the current fiscal year.

The Ministry has allocated Rs. 800,000 for this purpose. According to the Ministry, programmes will be launched to generate awareness about education, health and other sectors. The government has been providing an allowance of Rs. 4,000 to each person in the Raute community.

Nepalgunj prepares to ban tobacco products

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 24

To prepare for the ban, an awareness-generating programme will be conducted throughout the municipality before April 13.

Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitan City has announced a comprehensive ban on tobacco products within the city, effective from April 13, 2024. The decision to completely prohibit the consumption and sale of tobacco products was made during a meeting convened to address the control and regulation of such items.

Ram Bahadur Chand, the Head of the Health Division, informed that a meeting chaired by Prashant Bista, Mayor of Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitan City, decided to implement the ban as a priority. To prepare for the ban, an awareness-generating programme will be conducted throughout the municipality before April 13, Chand said.

"This initiative aims to educate the public about the harmful effects of tobacco products through various means. Additionally, awareness notice boards will be prominently displayed in the sub-metropolitan office, ward offices, and all offices within the city. Organizations and businesses involved in the production, sale, and distribution of tobacco products will also be required to provide data as part of this effort," he said. Mayor Bista shared details about the decision, emphasising the importance of a preparatory campaign alongside awareness promotion before the ban comes into effect.

During the meeting, Pushkar Nepal, Deputy Secretary of the Government of Nepal, urged local governments to exercise vigilance to ensure the effective implementation of regulations outlined in the Federal Act concerning the control and regulation of tobacco products.

Key figures such as Om Bahadur Khadka, Chief Administrative Officer, Lal Bahadur Gurung, Assistant Chief District Officer, and other stakeholders were present during the meeting. While the decision has been welcomed by residents, some have expressed reservations about the implementation of the complete ban.

Janamat Party quits Madhes province government

RSS
Janakpurdham, Jan. 24

Janamat Party withdrew its support and quit the Madhes province government. Minister for Education and Culture and Minister for Labour and Transport who were participating in the government on behalf of the Janamat Party submitted resignation letters to Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav.

Spokesperson of the Madhes province government and Minister for Home, Communications and Law Mohammad Samim informed that the ministers from the Janamat Party had collectively submitted their resignation to Chief Minister Yadav.

Earlier, Janamat Party's parliamentary party leader and Minister for Education and Culture Mahesh Prasad Yadav had submitted a letter to the Madhes Province Chief Hari Shanker Mishra withdrawing its support to the government.

Yadav shared that the ministers from Janamat Party had resigned since the government after a year of its formation failed to perform effectively and did not allow atmosphere for the ministers of his party to function well. The Janamat Party has 13 province assembly members in the Madhes.

TWO CHILDREN BECOME HELPLESS AFTER ARREST OF THEIR PARENTS

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bara, Jan. 24

Two children of the same family have been pushed into trouble after their father and mother were arrested for allegedly murdering their other daughter.

The body of 13-year-old daughter Koshila Kumari Mahato was found six months after she went missing from Triveni Tole of Pheta Rural Municipality-1 in Bara district. The deceased was an eighth grader at Benga Secondary School, Prasauni.

District Police Office, Bara, detained Koshila's parents Manju Devi and Harindra after police suspected their hands in the killing. Their eldest daughter Shosita Mahato and son, Suraj, have now nobody in the house to take care of them and manage daily earnings.

About 1.1 million people enrolled in health insurance drive in Lumbini

BY LAXMAN POUDEL
Bhairahawa, Jan. 24

Approximately 1.1 million residents in Lumbini Province have enrolled in health insurance over the past three years, according to the Health Insurance Board of Lumbini Province.

Janak Bahadur Saud, Coordinator of Insurance Board Lumbini, expressed satisfaction with this significant increase in citizen participation.

"It is a positive sign that a considerable number of citizens have embraced health insurance within these three years. We anticipate a further surge in enrollments in the coming year," said Saud.

Since the inception of health insurance services in the province three years ago, the board's data reveals that 1,092,673 individuals have secured insurance coverage. "This figure represents 21.33 per cent of the total population of the province. Our ongoing efforts are geared towards extending coverage to the entire citizenry," added Saud.

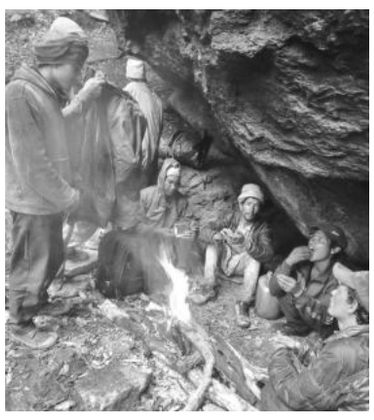
The total population of the Lumbini Province stands at 5,122,078. Out of this, 1,092,673 individuals are insured, with 524,770 men, 567,787 women, and 117 others included in the coverage. "The rapid increase in the number of insured citizens is an encouraging trend. We are optimistic that, over time, the programme's effectiveness will lead to the inclusion of all citizens," he said.

Saud outlined ongoing initiatives to cover the remaining 79 per cent of the province's citizens in the insurance programme. According to board data, 236,717 people have enrolled in health insurance in Palpa. The health insurance programme, initiated in Palpa in 2017, was progressively extended to all 12 districts in the province.

Rupandehi district boasts 161,581 insured citizens, Bardiya has 128,996, Gulmi has 107,312, Kapilvastu has 104,048, Arghakhanchi has 82,116, and Banke has 71,205 enrolled individuals. Similarly, 63,886 citizens are insured in Pyuthan, 45,003 in Dang, 44,168 in Nawalparasi West, and 38,939 in Rolpa.

The Health Insurance Board office reports that Rukum East has the lowest number of insured individuals at just 8,702. The insurance programme has significantly facilitated citizens' access to healthcare services. Consequently, the board encourages everyone to actively participate in the programme, with Saud emphasizing, "There are numerous benefits to having insurance, and timely enrolment ensures you advantages."

HERB COLLECTORS SPEND THREE MONTHS IN CAVES



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan. 24

The locals of the southern villages of Changkheli Rural Municipality in Humla district have to stay in caves for months while collecting herbs from the forests. The herb collectors have been staying in the caves at night due to a lack of houses in the area and tents to spend the nights.

Jaimal Budha, a local of Changkheli Rural Municipality, said that they had to walk for a whole day to reach Changkheli forest, and they had to live in the caves while collecting the herbs. He said, "We collect the herbs in the jungle throughout the day and live in the cave at night for about three months."

He said they prepared meals by making fires near the caves. He said, "We carry rice, vegetables, utensils and beds from home and sleep in the cave by making fires in the night."

He said that the locals of more than nine villages of Changkheli Rural Municipality have been living in the four caves of the forest while collecting herbs for many years. As it did not snow this year till the last week of January, the locals are still busy collecting herbs, Budha said.

Another herb collector, Ubjan Rokaya, who has been living in the cave every time he reaches the forest to harvest herbs, said that cold made their life difficult in the night. He has been collecting herbs continuously for the last 15 years. The income from herbs collecting is good but there is a fear of being affected by cold-related diseases as they have to sleep in the cold cave, he said.

There are four caves in the forest and after October/November, the herb collectors occupy them. The locals spend almost three months in the caves of the forest.

NEWS BRIEF

Van kills motorcyclist

Dharan: A HiAce van killed a motorcyclist in Dharan on Tuesday. The van, numbered Na 1 Ja 7121, travelling from Itahari to Dharan, hit a motorcycle, Ko 6 Pa 5603, and a scooter, Ko 32 Pa 8661, crossing the road at Bhotepul, Dharan Sub-Metropolitan City-8 at 2 pm Tuesday.

According to Deputy Superintendent of Police Navaraj Malla of the Area Police Office Dharan, the motorcycle rider, identified as 46-year-old Sambhu Darji, sustained serious injuries and was declared dead on arrival by the BP Koirala Institute of Health Sciences.

The scooter rider, 44-year-old Suraj Gajmer, only sustained minor injuries. The HiAce van and its driver 28-year-old Tej Narayan Sada are currently in police custody.

Two girls injured in bear attack

Achham: Two girls were injured when a bear attacked them at Ramaroshan Rural Municipality -5 in Achham district.

Nineteen-year-old Parbati Shah and Kiran Shah, 20, were attacked by a wild animal when collecting fodder for animals at local Salimkot community forest, said the District Police Office Chief, Deputy Superintendent Santosh Pathak.

According to him, both girls have injuries in several parts of the body and deep lacerations in the heads. Kiran is in an unconscious condition while Parbati is in moderate health.

DSP Pathak said preparations had been made for airlifting the two injured girls and sending them to a hospital in the next district for advanced treatment.

TRN

Local levels delay distributing grant to Jajarkot quake victims

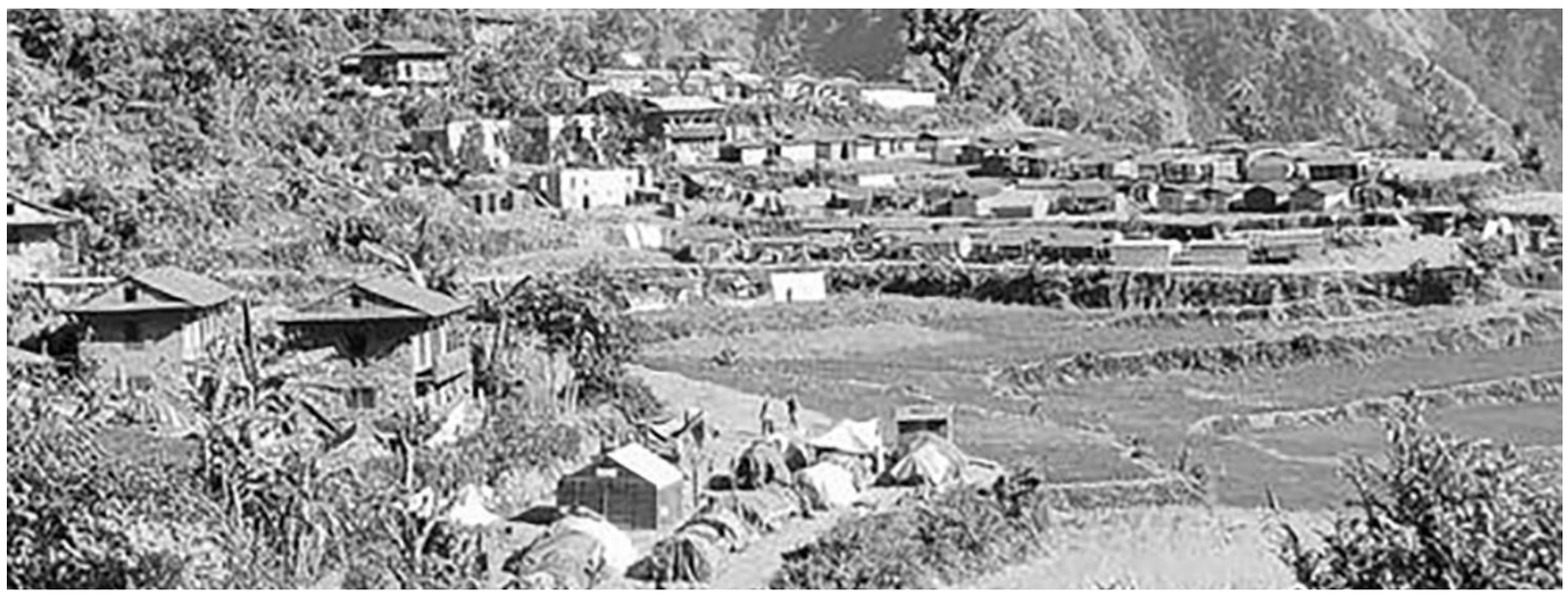


PHOTO: TRN

The earthquake victims of Jajarkot are still in temporary houses.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Jan. 24

Local levels have delayed the distribution of the grant sent by the federal government for the construction of temporary housing for the earthquake-affected victims in Jajarkot district.

Even 82 days after the earthquake, the people enlisted as beneficiaries for the grant are spending cold winter nights under tarpaulins and tents as they have not received the grant money for constructing the temporary housing. As a result, the quake victims have been suffering from cold-induced illnesses.

Until now, all the families should have built temporary housing and moved to a warmer place, but due to the delay in distributing the grant on the part of the local levels, the victims have been in trouble.

The victims are to get Rs. 25,000 as the first tranche of the grant to begin temporary housing, but when the local bodies have delayed transferring the budget and confirming additional beneficiaries, the victims are facing difficulty in building temporary shelters.

Although Jajarkot has 42,524 beneficiaries, 28,682 beneficiaries signed an agreement with the local government for the first instalment. Of them, 27,735 beneficiaries have received their first tranche of about Rs. 693 million at the rate of 25,000.

These first tranche amounts were distributed in Bheri, Nalgadh, Chhedagaadh municipalities, and Barekot, Kushe, Shivalaya, Junichande rural municipalities.

Harish Chandra Sharma, Information Officer and Administrative Officer of the District Administration Office, said that a total of 10,341 temporary housings have been constructed so far in the municipalities. The federal government has provided Rs. 1.3 billion as housing grant to the district.

CLASSIFIED DISPLAY

Certificate Lost

Date 2080/07/05, Migration Certificate got lost while travelling from Jawalakhel to Bhaisepati . So, I Humbly request Someone who has found it to inform to the nearby police station or contatct to the mobile number 9847376029 .
Reg. No. : 75719058
Issued by : NEB board
Name : Lydia Hamal
Address : Jaya Prithivi, Muncipality Bajhang .

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Victory belongs to the most persevering.
-- Napoleon Bonaparte

EDITORIAL

Monument Restoration

Rapid urbanisation is the trend of modern society. People are migrating to cities so that they have easy access to basic amenities. This has naturally put pressure on the cities that are steeped in rich cultural heritage and historical monuments. The capital cities are known for their old forts, temples and buildings that demonstrate ancient art and architectural marvel. Now priority has been shifted to constructing big buildings such as business malls and residential apartments, and wide roads to facilitate the movement of people through a vast network of transportation system. This demands more land, which might give rise to the encroachment of the public land and property. Aggressive development and management deficiencies have threatened precious cultural heritages, which enable people to better understand the society while contributing to the growth of local communities and satisfaction of their spiritual needs. Thus, there lies humongous challenge to carry out sustainable urban development and protect the cultural heritage side by side.

The Kathmandu Valley is famous for its ancient culture, art and artefacts found in temples, shrines, stupas, sattals and resting places. Many of them are old and rickety, requiring their immediate renovation, repairing and maintenance. There are also encouraging initiatives to conserve them, with the assistance from the government, NGOs and donor agencies. According to a news report published in this daily on Wednesday, around 28 monuments, which were located along the Bagmati River corridor in Teku Dovan to Thapathali but damaged during the 2015 earthquake, have been reconstructed to their originals shape. The historical river-bank structures that included ghats, sattals, temples and shrines were built during the rule of Rana prime minister Janga Bahadur. The Bagmati River Basin Improvement Project-Additional Financing (BRBIP-AF) had launched campaign to restore the monuments in 2020, with financial support from the Asian Development Bank.

The BRBIP aims to improve the health of the river and manage flood within the Bagmati River Basin in line with the Bagmati Action Plan that envisions a clean, green and healthy Bagmati River that is full of life and vigour. As per this objective, it has reconstructed notable ghats. These include Teku-Dovan Ghat, Munshi Ghat, Panchanari Ghat, Pachali Ghat, Hanuman Ghat, Kali Ghat, Kaji Ghat, Puret Ghat, Juddha Ghat, Chandra Ghat, and Kal Mochan Ghat. These ghats along the corridor provide cultural and historical richness in the locality. They were built with the objective of providing places for cremation and rest. Some of them even served as lodgings. Other reconstructed monuments include Karki Sattal, Manandhar Sattal, Shiva Temple, Munsi Ghat Sattal, Pujari Sattal, and Teen Dewal Temple Gateway to Bomkiteswar. Traditional methods and materials such as lime, sand, surkhi, molasses, and crushed black lentil were applied in reconstructing these monuments.

The renovated monuments have indeed enhanced the beauty of the holy river corridors. Many sattals have been decorated with carved wooden structures, with sculpted pillars, windows, balconies, doors and architectural adornments like struts and tympanum. Undoubtedly, the restored monuments have increased the prospects for tourism and income generation for the local people. However, the concerned authorities are worried about their proper management. Some structures have already been handed over to guthis but there are significant number of monuments that need to be handed over to certain agencies to take care of. The Kathmandu Metropolitan City is the appropriate body for their operational management as they fall into its territory.

Check Youth Exodus

BRITTI ARYAL

The number of people going abroad for foreign employment has significantly increased these days. Every day many people can be seen at the international airport, leaving the country for better job opportunities. With the skilled workers flying off to foreign lands, the country has been left with very limited proficient minds and an aging population only. Employment opportunities have been scarce at home, compelling the youth and skilled manpower to go abroad.

People are frustrated with the income they get after all the hard work done. Despite Nepal being an agricultural country, people had not been able to do proper farming due to the lack of resources. Authorities haven't been able to fulfill the demands of local farmers to execute cultivation properly. Nor have they been able to supply chemical fertilizers at reasonable rates to sell the products they grow. People who have started the business also aren't able to generate sufficient profits to survive. Labors aren't happy with the wages they get. Their income isn't even sufficient to cover their basic needs. Many students who have completed their education haven't got suitable jobs.

Those who have jobs have very low incomes despite having good qualification. People from all walks of life are facing this problem. Amid such scenario, everybody wants to switch to better options with good employment opportunities and greater income. In the absence of able workforce, colleges, factories, offices, and even local businesses are on the verge of shutting down. The financial misery inflicted by unemployment and growing inflation has created a huge brain drain in the country. With the surge in the unemployment rate, the economic growth rate has also slumped and the country is facing economic crisis soon. But none of the political parties seem serious about addressing the people's desperation.

The government has pledged to solve the issue several times but has not taken any steps to retain skilled individuals. Instead of offering opportunities to youths, the government's tendency to let workers go abroad, citing their contribution through remittance is quite surprising and miserable. If the situation continues, there will be no one left to look after the country. The government must take steps to spur economic growth and create enough jobs. Authorities need to do something concrete to bring the inflation down and stop mass exodus.

Establishing export-oriented industries and enhancing employment access through information systems might be a good initiative. Local and small businesses need to be promoted to reduce the import of goods that can be easily produced in the country. The government needs to provide the required resources in the required field at reasonable prices to promote domestic employment. Conducting skill development training programmes will help generate skilled manpower to perform particular tasks, lowering the unemployment rate. Authorities need to come up with new plans like rewarding returnees from foreign employment which encourages youngsters to come back to the country with good hope. The government must resolve the issue to prevent the exodus of young entrepreneurs.

Judges' Role In Mediation Services

Mukti Rijal



Alternative dispute resolution (ADR) mechanisms, especially mediation, have become massively popular in Nepal. Mediation has been made institutionally an integral part of dispute resolution in the courts across three levels – District Court, High Court and Supreme Court - for last two decades. Similarly, local governments have been constitutionally mandated to create such mechanism as judicial committee to resolve disputes primarily through recourse to mediation. In case mediation fails, judicial committees can take resort to adjudication to resolve cases especially listed in section 47(1) of the local governance operation act 2017.

Though some books and articles focused on different aspects of mediation in Nepal can be accessed, these are basically written with reference to normative and legal-institutional perspectives. There is a sheer deficit of systematic studies and investigations using empirical data collected through discussions and interviews with mediation users and stakeholders in Nepal. Such studies can alone ascertain and bring to fore the relevant practical and behavioral issues to account for the state of implementation of mediation and their effectiveness in delivering justice to the people.

Ambience of judiciary

Recently, a preliminary survey on the state of mediation conducted under the joint auspices of National Judicial Academy and Mediation Council based on some secondary data has discussed some issues and aspects. The study report had been shared with a critical group of users and stakeholders at an interaction programme. The study spells out the growth trajectory of mediation across all jurisdictions especially in the court, community and local neighborhoods. The report shows the relatively poor situation of case referral by judges to the process of court connected mediation. Moreover, larger percentage of the cases - as their type and the issues involved show - registered in the district courts could be settled through a recourse to process of mediation.

This indicates that the district court judges - the court of first instance - seem, due to one or the other reasons, to be more attuned to adjudicatory process than referring cases to mediation. From the data produced in the study it can be concluded that the absence of a conducive environment for mediation is partly attributable to the lack of judges' understanding, institutional incentives, proper guidelines and orientation in regard to mediation in the districts. The success of the court connected mediation is linked to the number of referrals a judge makes and how mediation friendly is the ambience of judiciary. When we talk about the ambience of judiciary congenial to mediation, it includes the commitment and suitability of judges, lawyers, core staff of the courts, institutional and physical infrastructures to facilitate the process of mediation.

The role of a referral judge in determining the possibility of settling a dispute through mediation has also been recognised properly in such countries as Malaysia, Sri Lanka, India and so on. The referral judge can play an instrumental role in building the parties' positive perception about mediation, which can significantly influence their willingness to opt and actively co-operate during the process of mediation. If judges are not equipped and motivated to handle and refer cases for mediation, it may have poor consequences for the outcome of such efforts. The disputing parties need to have confidence in the process, which cannot be fostered through a mechanical referral of a dispute to mediation.

> Even if mediation is mandated for some or all civil disputes, the onus is on the referral judge, lawyers and legal counsel to ensure that parties enter the process of mediation willingly with an open mind.

Even if mediation is mandated for some or all civil disputes, the onus is on the referral judge, lawyers and legal counsel to ensure that parties enter the process of mediation willingly with an open mind. In fact, the potential of mediation lies across case types and different stages in the court adjudicatory process. This is also borne out by the experience of countries such as Australia where mediation has been found to be successful in diverse cases even at advanced stages of litigation. However, for this to occur successfully, role of a referral judge needs to be clarified in the rules and guidelines so as to enable him or her to tactfully convince parties to attempt mediating settlement of disputes, even in unconventional and complicated cases.

There are several instances to show that efforts through mediation contribute to result in the settlement of complicated disputes even at the appellate stage. The complex and unconventional disputes have been referred to mediation because of the efforts of the referral judges and legal counsels who could persuade parties to attempt at mediating disputes settlement. Taking cues from such instances, proper guidelines need to be worked out for referral judges in Nepal. In Australia, for instance, National Alternative Dispute Resolution Advisory Council has laid down guidelines to ascertain suitability of cases and referral for mediation.

Training and accreditation

Even as the role of the judge in referring cases necessarily involves exercise of certain discretionary power, laying down of the criteria and guidelines for such decision making can contribute to more consistent patterns in the kind of cases that get referred for mediation. This contributes to create a more uniform and cohesive development of court-connected mediation. Training and accreditation of mediators training programmes have been recognised as a necessity for mediators in almost all jurisdictions. Pre-mediation preparation, understanding positions, interests and needs, effective communication and handling skills, negotiation facilitation, understanding neutrality and confidentiality, have been key elements of effective mediation process.

There is a widespread recognition of the fact that awareness building and usage will increase only if there is a quality of mediation service accessible to the needy people. In Nepal, needless to say, mediation council is in place as an enabling and regulatory body to conceptualise and formulate training curriculum, coordinate and monitor the training programmes and accredit the mediators. However, it is noted that the regulatory body lacks capacity and there has been a sheer lack of provision of training quality assurance and monitoring to ensure effectiveness of mediation services.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Ensure Effective Role Of NAM

Uttam Maharjan



The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) is the biggest group of nations after the United Nations (UN). The movement was founded in 1961 in Belgrade based on the principles adopted at the Bangdung conference held in 1955. The movement was established at a time when the Cold War was raging between the two powerful blocs in the world: the ex-Soviet bloc whose best known alliance was the Warsaw Pact and the pro-American bloc with many members belonging to NATO. The Cold War was a conflict of ideology and military strength that began after the end of World War II in 1945. The Western Bloc was a capitalist bloc under the leadership of the US and included most of western Europe, Canada, Australia and Japan. On the other hand, the Eastern Bloc was a communist bloc led by the Soviet Union. The two blocs were contending over which economic system – capitalist or communist – should prevail in the world.

NAM emerged after the Korean War, which lasted for three years from 1950 to 1953, to counterbalance the growing bipolarisation during the Cold War. During the Cold War, the two blocs were trying to include the rest of the world in their folds. The movement aimed at counteracting the West's unilateral approaches and actions on the world stage.

Basic thrust

The basic thrust of NAM was to fight imperialism, colonialism and neocolonialism, racism, aggression, occupation, domination, outside interference, hegemony, action by great powers and bloc politics. The principles of the movement include respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity, rejection of unconstitutional change of government or external attempts to change government, freedom to determine political, social, economic and cultural systems; rejection of aggression or direct or indirect use of force, and opposition to use of unilateral political, economic or military measures. Its primary objectives were neutrality, national independence, preservation of sovereignty, territorial integrity and security.

Over the first three decades, NAM achieved breakthroughs in its objectives. It played a pivotal role in decolonisation, creation of independent countries and democratisation of international relations. Its other major successes included disarmament, opposition to racism and opposition to the apartheid system in South Africa. The South African apartheid system that segregated blacks from whites in every sector was finally dismantled in the early 1990s. And a democratic government was formed in 1994. Likewise, many colonised countries, especially in Asia and Africa, became independent. It may, however, be mentioned that the waves of decolonisation had emerged before the establishment of the movement.

Emerging with just 25 members, NAM has now 120 members, two-thirds of the UN members. (the UN has 193 members.) It also includes 19 countries with observer status and 10 organisations. The members of the movement represent 55 per cent of the world population. The movement has no formal constitution, nor does it have a permanent secretariat. All the members have equal rights. Decisions are taken by consensus at summit conferences of heads of state or government. Such summit conferences are usually held every three years.

> In a world where powerful countries are on the go for their self-interests, the relevance of the movement has grown more than ever before.

In a world where powerful countries are on the go for their self-interests, the relevance of the movement has grown more than ever before.

The Cold War ended in 1991 with the Balkanisation of the Soviet Union, which resulted in the creation of a unipolar world with the US assuming the reins of a single superpower. Even after the Cold War ended, NAM did not cease to exist. As usual, the activities of the movement proceeded with the holding of summit conferences in Indonesia in 1992, Columbia in 1995 and South Africa in 1997. However, the focus of the movement has shifted to fostering multilateral ties and building and consolidating unity among the developing and least developed countries, especially those in the Global South. In a conflict-ridden world, mutual respect, cooperation, solidarity and esprit de corps are acutely needed.

NAM is in favour of reforms in the UN. It believes that the structure of the UN Security Council is such that it is being used by powerful countries, including the five permanent members with veto powers, in ways that violate the sacrosanct principles adopted by it. The movement has made several recommendations aimed at bolstering the representation of the developing and least developed countries in the UN. It has also sought transparency of the decision-making process at the UN as well as the use of democratic methods for taking decisions. There are instances in which major decisions cannot be taken owing to the veto power of one of the veto-wielding permanent members of the Security Council. NAM has advocated the comity of nations, international cooperation, multilateralism and national self-determination. It has raised its voice against the inequities of the world economic order. The gaps between the haves and the have-nots are growing unabated. The movement is trying to bridge such gaps as far as possible.

World order

We are now in the 21st century. The world order has changed from what was prevailing during the Cold War. NAM lived through the Cold War era despite several conflicts between its members and despite some of its members siding with the Soviet Union, the US or China. A major condition of the movement is that its members should not join any major power blocs such as NATO. Such things may happen in any regional or world group. The movement should show finesse in dealing with such matters so as to maintain cohesion among its members.

Non-alignment does not mean remaining passive or neutral in the international field. NAM should be revitalised keeping abreast with the changing times so as to meet the 21st century needs of the Third World. It should be able to give a voice to the developing and least developed countries. It should closely monitor world affairs and take action accordingly for the benefit of its members. In a world where powerful countries are on the go for their self-interests, the relevance of the movement has grown more than ever before. Its relevance cannot be negated as long as the sovereign state system exists in the world.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 25, 1974

Special Police Initiates Investigation

Kathmandu, Jan. 24: Special Police has initiated investigation on the charge of corruption against head assistant Ram Chandra Pradhan of Nepal Philatelic Bureau, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Winter In Kathmandu



I am writing this in reference to a news report titled "*Kathmandu records lowest minimum temperature so far this year*" published in the digital version of this daily on Jan. 22.

Kathmandu experiences a chilling cold in the winter season. And on Monday, January 22, it recorded the lowest temperature (3.2 degrees Celsius) of this year as people had to brace the cold. Cold can be quite difficult to overcome, especially for the elderly, the infirm and children.

Hospitals see a rise in cold and flu patients. People try out ways to keep warm through heaters and air conditioners. Compared to other cities such as Pokhara, Kathmandu has a severe cold. It is marked by fogs in the mornings and a harsh cold during evenings and nights.

While the valley has a mild and pleasant summer, its winter can be quite debilitating. Already, Kathmandu citizens are hoping that the temperature will rise in the upcoming days as they face the chill that affects their daily routine.

Khem Neupane
Palpa

TAILPIECE

Junior had just received his brand new driver's license. To celebrate, the whole family trooped out to the driveway and climbed into the car for his inaugural drive. Dad immediately headed to the back seat, directly behind the newly minted driver.

"I'll bet you're back there to get a change of scenery after all those months of sitting in the front passenger seat teaching me how to drive," said the beaming boy to his ol' man.

"Nope," came dad's reply, "I'm gonna sit here and kick the back of your seat as you drive, just like you've been doing to me for sixteen years."

US strikes militia sites in Iraq

AP
Washington, Jan. 24



PHOTO: AP

In this image provided by the UK Ministry of Defence, a Royal Air Force Typhoon FGR4 takes off to carry out air strikes against Houthi military targets in Yemen, from RAF Akrotiri, Cyprus, Monday, Jan. 22, 2024.

The U.S. military struck three facilities in Iraq and two anti-ship missiles in Yemen operated by Iranian-backed militias that have attacked U.S. personnel and ships in the region as the United States tries to keep the Israel-Hamas war from spilling over into a wider conflict.

Both the strikes in Iraq and Yemen late on Tuesday targeted sites that the U.S. has said are involved in the attacks against U.S. forces in Iraq and Syria and were threatening U.S. military and commercial vessels in the Red Sea.

U.S. Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin said in a statement that the strikes in Iraq were at the direction of President Joe Biden and targeted facilities used by the Iranian-backed Kataib Hezbollah militia and other Iran-affiliated groups in Iraq.

"These precision strikes are in direct response to a series of escalatory attacks against U.S. and Coalition personnel in Iraq and Syria by Iranian-sponsored militias," Austin said. Those strikes hit militia facilities in Jurf al-Sakhar, which is south of Baghdad, al-Qaim and another unnamed site in western Iraq, two U.S. officials said.

Iraq's Prime Minister Mohammed Shia al-Sudani said the strikes "blatantly violate Iraq's sovereignty" and contribute to an "irresponsible escalation," according to a statement from his office. The statement, signed by military spokesman Yahya Rasool, said Iraq considers the strikes "hostile acts" and is taking measures to protect the lives of Iraqis.

The Popular Mobilization Forces, or PMF, a coalition of armed mostly Shiite groups only nominally under Iraqi military authority, said the strike near the Syrian border killed one of its fighters and wounded two, while the strike south of Baghdad caused material damage. The U.S. Central Command announced it had also struck two anti-ship missiles belonging to the Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels that were being prepared for launch and were aimed at the southern part of the Red Sea.

"U.S. forces identified the missiles in Houthi-controlled areas of Yemen and determined that they presented an imminent threat to merchant vessels and the U.S. Navy ships in the region," Central Command said.

Both fronts — land attacks in Iraq and Syria, and sea attacks originating from Yemen — have seen a significant uptick in launches and counterstrikes' over the last few days.

The U.S. strikes on the Kataib Hezbollah sites in Iraq came hours after the U.S. said militiamen fired two one-way attack drones at al-Asad Air Base, injuring U.S. service members and damaging infrastructure. And they followed the militia's most serious attack this year on the air base, when it launched multiple ballistic missiles on Saturday.

U.S. Central Command said it targeted Kataib Hezbollah headquarters, storage, and training locations for rocket, missile, and one-way attack drone capabilities.

In the drone attacks against al-Asad earlier Tuesday, U.S. defenses were able to intercept the first drone but it crashed on base while the second drone hit the base, U.S. officials said. Injuries, including traumatic brain injuries and smoke inhalation, were reported to be minor. The officials spoke on the condition of anonymity to provide details that had not been announced publicly.

The strikes on the Houthi missile launch sites in Yemen followed a joint operation on Monday night where the U.S. and Britain used warship- and submarine-launched Tomahawk missiles and fighter jets to take out Houthi missile storage sites, drones and launchers.

On both fronts, the Iranian-backed militias have employed ballistic missiles to target U.S. bases and ships, which marks an escalation, said Behnam Ben Taleblu, a senior fellow at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies who specializes in Iran.

The militias have typically used drones and rockets to attack. Tehran supplied Shiite militias in Iraq with short-range and close-range ballistic missiles in 2019, Taleblu said, but they had not been used until November's attacks.

Earthquake hits western China

AP
Uchturpan, China, Jan. 24

As aftershocks continued to rock western China on Wednesday, more than 12,000 people were staying in tents and other shelters, lighting bonfires to fend off the freezing weather.

The previous day, a magnitude 7.1 earthquake in a remote part of China's Xinjiang region killed three people and left five injured, while damaging hundreds of buildings.

The quake caused significant damage amid freezing temperatures, but the toll on lives and property was relatively light, owing to the sparse population around the epicentre in Uchturpan county, near the border with Kazakhstan.

Footage shown by state broadcaster CCTV on Wednesday showed evacuees eating instant noodles in tents with bonfires providing heat.

Jian Gewa, a 16-year old student in Uchturpan, said he was in the bathroom when the quake began. The entire building shook violently.

"I just thought I had to get myself to safety as quickly as possible," Jian said.

He was evacuated to a school where he was staying in a dorm room with his grandfather, joining about 200 others. Local officials said they planned to check houses' stability before people could return.

The earthquake hit in a sparsely populated area with clusters of towns and villages scattered across an otherwise barren winter landscape. A two lane highway runs from the city of Aksu about 125 kilometres to the area, through frozen brown flatlands on one side and craggy outcroppings on the other. Power lines and an occasional cement factory are virtually the only signs of human presence.

In Kizilsu Kirgiz prefecture, the earthquake caused damage of various degrees to 851 buildings, collapsing 93 structures near the epicentre and killing 910 livestock, according to the prefecture deputy party secretary Wurouziali Haxihaerbayi.

The area is populated mostly by Kyrgyz and Uyghurs, ethnic Turkic minorities who are predominantly Muslim and have been the target of a state campaign of forced assimilation and mass detention. The region is heavily militarized, and state broadcaster CCTV showed paramilitary troops moving in before dawn to clear rubble and set up tents for those displaced.

Two of the three people who died were members of a Kyrgyz sheep herding family who had brought their flock up the mountain and spent the night in their rest hut, said Shi Chao, the Communist Party head of Kulansarike township.

Rescuers found the family of three, including a 6-year old girl, and brought them down the mountain but only the father survived, Shi said.

The township has been replacing the huts with sturdier structures partially subsidized by the government, he said. The third death happened elsewhere in Akqi county.

The prefecture has deployed more than 2,300 rescuers, and Akqi county evacuated 7,338 residents. In total, 12,426 people have been evacuated.

Rescue crews combed through the rubble while emergency survival gear including coats and tents arrived to help the thousands of people who fled their homes.

Heavy fighting in Khan Younis leaves patients stranded in hospital

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 24

Israeli forces battled Palestinian militants Wednesday near the main hospital in Gaza's second-largest city of Khan Younis, where medics said hundreds of patients and thousands of displaced people were unable to leave because of the fighting.

Israel has ordered residents to leave a swath of downtown Khan Younis that includes Nasser and two smaller hospitals as it pushes ahead with its 3-month-old offensive against Hamas. The United Nations humanitarian office said the area was home to 88,000 Palestinians and was hosting another 425,000 displaced by fighting elsewhere.

The aid group Doctors Without Borders said its staff was trapped inside Nasser Hospital with some 850 patients and thousands of displaced people because the surrounding roads were inaccessible or too dangerous. Nasser Hospital is one of only two hospitals in southern Gaza that can still treat critically ill patients, the group said. Gaza's Health Ministry also said the hospital had been isolated.

The Israeli military said its forces were battling militants inside Khan Younis after completing their encirclement of the city the day before. It said aircraft were striking targets as part of the operations there and had also targeted suspected militants in central and northern Gaza.

Thousands of people fled south from Khan Younis on Tuesday toward the town of Rafah. The U.N. says some 1.5 million people — around two-thirds of Gaza's population — are crowded into shelters and tent camps in and around Rafah, which is on the border with Egypt.

Even there, Palestinians have found little safety, with Israel regularly carrying out strikes in and around the town. Palestinian witnesses said that in recent days Israeli soldiers and tanks had pushed into parts of Muwasi, a sandy area along the coast that Israel had declared a safe zone, where tens of thousands of people were living in tents without basic services.

In all, some 1.7 million people have been displaced within Gaza, according to the U.N. refugee agency. Most have fled from the north, where Israel's air and ground offensive has reduced entire neighborhoods to shelled-out wastelands, raising the question of whether residents will ever be able to return.

Gaza's Health Ministry says the offensive has killed at least 25,490 people — the majority women and children — and wounded another 63,354. Its count does not differentiate between civilians and combatants. U.N. officials have expressed fears that even more people could die from disease, with at least one-quarter of the population facing starvation.

NKorea fired several cruise missiles into sea: Seoul

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Jan. 24

South Korea's military said Wednesday that North Korea fired several cruise missiles into waters off its western coast, as an analysis of commercial satellite images suggested that the North has torn down a huge arch in its capital that symbolised reconciliation with war-divided rival South Korea.

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un last week described the Pyongyang monument as an "eyesore" and called for its removal while declaring that the North was abandoning long-standing goals of a peaceful unification with South Korea and ordered a rewriting of the North's constitution to define the South as its most hostile foreign adversary.

The launches marked North Korea's second known launch event of the year, following a Jan. 14 test-firing of the country's first solid-fuel intermediate range ballistic missile, which reflected its efforts to advance its line-up of weapons targeting U.S. military bases in Japan and Guam.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said Wednesday that the U.S. and South Korean militaries were analyzing the latest launches. It did not immediately confirm the exact number of missiles fired or their specific flight details.

"Our military has increased surveillance and vigilance and is closely coordinating with the United States while monitoring for further signs and activity from North Korea," the Joint Chiefs of Staff said in a statement.



PHOTO: AP

A TV screen shows a report of North Korea's cruise missiles with file footage during a news program at the Seoul Railway Station in Seoul, South Korea, Wednesday, Jan. 24, 2024.

Tensions on the Korean Peninsula have increased in recent months as Kim continues to accelerate his weapons development and issue provocative threats of nuclear conflict with the United States and its Asian allies.

NK News, a North Korea-focused news site, reported that Pyongyang's Monument to the Three Charters for National Reunification, which was also commonly called the Arch of Reunification, appeared gone in satellite images taken by Planet Labs Tuesday morning, although it was unclear exactly when or how it was taken down. The Associated Press couldn't immediately confirm the report independently.

The arch was a 30-metre (about 100-foot) tall structure that looked over a highway leading to the city of Kaesong near the border with South Korea.

The United States, South Korea and Japan have been expanding their combined military exercises in response to the North's missiles tests. Kim characterizes these drills as rehearsals for an invasion.

PRISM

California woman grows world's longest arm hair

California: A California woman earned a Guinness World Records title when a single strand of hair growing out of her bicep was measured at 7.24 inches long.

Macie Davis-Southerland told Guinness World Records she didn't discover her unusually long arm hair until 2012, when she was a junior in high school.

"I was at Disneyland with my best friend Kaylee's family when her brother pointed out a hair on my arm," Davis-Southerland said. "He was telling me that I had an extremely long hair, and his original thought was to pull it!"

Alligator makes hole in pond to survive winter

Texas: A Texas wildlife rescue centre shared video of an alligator poking its snout through the ice so it can survive in a frozen pond.

The video, posted to TikTok, shows a resident alligator at Gator Country in Beaumont with its body under the ice, but its snout sticking up through a small hole. Gator Country owner Gary Saurage explains in the video that the gator's seemingly unusual position is normal winter weather behaviour for the cold-blooded animals.

Alligators in freezing temperatures go into a state of brumation, a cold-blooded animal's version of hibernation.

(AP)

Count of homeless residents begins in LA

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 24



PHOTO: AP

Los Angeles City Council President Paul Krekorian, right, joined by Supervisor Kathryn Barger, centre, who represents the 5th supervisorial district of Los Angeles County, walks on the streets at the start of the annual homeless count in the North Hollywood section of Los Angeles Tuesday, Jan. 23, 2024.

Los Angeles County's annual count of homeless residents began Tuesday night — a crucial part of the region's efforts to confront the crisis of tens of thousands of people living on the streets.

Up to 6,000 volunteers with the Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority fanned out for the effort's main component, the unsheltered street tally.

The so-called "point-in-time" count will take place over three days and aims to estimate how many people are unhoused and what services they may require, such as mental health or drug addiction treatment.

LA County's undertaking is the largest among similar tallies in major cities nationwide. The tally, which also makes use of demographic surveys and shelter counts, is mandated by the federal government for cities to receive certain kinds of funding.

The count this year comes amid increasing public outrage over the perceived failure — despite costly efforts — to reduce the surging population of people living in cars, tents and makeshift street shelters.

The 2023 effort reported more than 75,500 people were homeless on any given night in LA County, a 9% rise from a year earlier. About 46,200 were within the city of Los Angeles, where public frustration has grown as tents have proliferated on sidewalks and in parks and other locations.

Since 2015, homelessness has increased by 70% in the county and 80% in the city.

Karen Bass, the mayor of Los Angeles, joined city and county officials to kick off the count Tuesday night in the North Hollywood neighbourhood of LA's San Fernando Valley.

The count "is an important tool to confront the homelessness crisis," Bass said in a statement. "Homelessness is an emergency, and it will take all of us working together to confront this emergency."

On her first day in office in Dec. 2022, Bass declared a state of emergency on homelessness. One year into her term, the mayor, a Democrat, announced that over 21,000 unhoused people were moved into leased hotels or other temporary shelter during 2023, a 28% increase from the prior year.

Dozens of drug-plagued street encampments were cleared, and housing projects are in the pipeline, she said last month.

City Hall, the City Council and the LA County Board of Supervisors have said they intend to work together to tackle the crisis. Progress hasn't always been apparent despite billions spent on programs to curb homelessness.

Homelessness remains hugely visible throughout California with people living in tents and cars and sleeping outdoors on sidewalks and under highway overpasses.

The results of the LA County homeless count are expected to be released in late spring or early summer.

TODAY IN HISTORY

41 – After a night of negotiation, Claudius is accepted as Roman emperor by the Senate.
750 – In the Battle of the Zab, the Abbasid rebels defeat the Umayyad Caliphate, leading to the overthrow of the dynasty.
1494 – Alfonso II becomes King of Naples.
1515 – Coronation of Francis I of France takes place at Reims Cathedral, where the new monarch is anointed with the oil of Clovis and girt
1792 – The London Corresponding Society is founded.
1858 – The Wedding March by Felix Mendelssohn is played at the marriage of Queen Victoria's daughter, Victoria, and Friedrich of Prussia, and becomes a popular wedding processional.
1879 – The Bulgarian National Bank is founded.
1881 – Thomas Edison and Alexander Graham Bell form the Oriental Telephone Company.
1890 – Nellie Bly completes her round-the-world journey in 72 days.

PRESENT COALITION WILL CONTINUE: DEUBA

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Jan. 24

Nepali Congress President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the ruling coalition was the need of the hours, and the Nepali Congress was committed to taking the coalition for the long term.

Speaking at the district conference of the Nepali Congress in Syangja on Wednesday, Deuba said that currently, no party was in a position to secure a majority. He said, "We have adopted a proportional election system. It will be difficult for any party to garner the majority."

He also stressed the need to retain the youth in the country by creating job opportunities for them.

Stating that development was taking place in the country after the political change of 2006, he said that the present system should be made more effective. Deuba urged NC cadres not to be disappointed as the party was committed to developing the country by uniting everyone.

Vice President of Nepali Congress and Minister of Law, Justice, and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung said that the Nepali Congress should be united for the development of the country.

Central member and former General Secretary Dr. Shashank Koirala said that the party was active and had a stronghold in Syangja.

Deputy General Secretary Jeevan Pariyar, Nepali Congress Central member and Gandaki Province Chief Minister Surendra Raj Pandey, Central member and Gandaki Provincial Minister for Energy, Water Resource and Drinking Water Saraswati Aryal and others also spoke on the occasion.

Sagarmatha...

"We have sought permission to initiate a new tender. The entire contracted amount from before has not been utilised. If the Ministry of Finance approves spending the remaining amount, we will commence the work after issuing the new tender. In total, four contracts for the Gaighat-Diktel section have been terminated. However, the funds allocated several years ago are insufficient for reopening the tender at present," Mishra added.

According to Mishra, due to a nearly double cost caused by increased prices, a new tender will be initiated for the road from Foksingtar to Mahure towards Khotang using the adjusted amount. The budget for the road towards Udayapur will need to be re-evaluated. Considering some landslide-prone areas, discussions are underway to revise the Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the road towards Udayapur.

Bhupendra Rai, Provincial Assembly Member for Khotang 'B' and General Secretary of the Koshi Province Committee of Nepali Congress, said that now that the estimates for the Mahure-Foksingtar road have been prepared and submitted to the Department of Road, the tender will be reopened shortly.

"The road department has the file now, and we will invite a new tender after getting approval from the Ministry of Finance to use the existing funds. We are confident about getting the permission. Currently, we are focused on the National Assembly elections. After the elections, we will approach the Ministry of Finance, secure the green signal, and then open the tender," Rai said.

The short road connecting Khotang to the Tarai region has remained unpaved for an extended period, raising concerns among citizens. Despite the construction of a concrete bridge over the Sunkoshi River at the Khotang-Udayapur border, vehicle movement is challenging due to the muddy and unpaved condition of the road.

CIAA arrests...

Panel (Part-A) at Rs. 2.2 million. The equipment bought five years ago has not been tested till date.

The CIAA demanded a fine of Rs. 2.2 million for all defendants and punishment in accordance with Clause 8 of the Prevention of Corruption Act-2002 with additional punishment in accordance with Clause 24 of the same act for Paudel.

Likewise, a team from CIAA in Tangal has arrested surveyor Rambir Yadav from Survey Office, Lalitpur with a bride of Rs. 250,000. The CIAA informed that the team was deployed after receiving a complaint against surveyor Yadav that he was demanding a bribe from the service seekers to prepare an ownership certificate after plotting the land. Further investigation into the incident was currently under way, informed the CIAA.

Govt will...

state of Australia Deepak Kumar Khadka.

The Cabinet has given authority to Ministry of Foreign Affairs to reach agreement on Memorandum of Understanding between Nepal and Qatar governments on a proposed diplomatic training and academic sector.

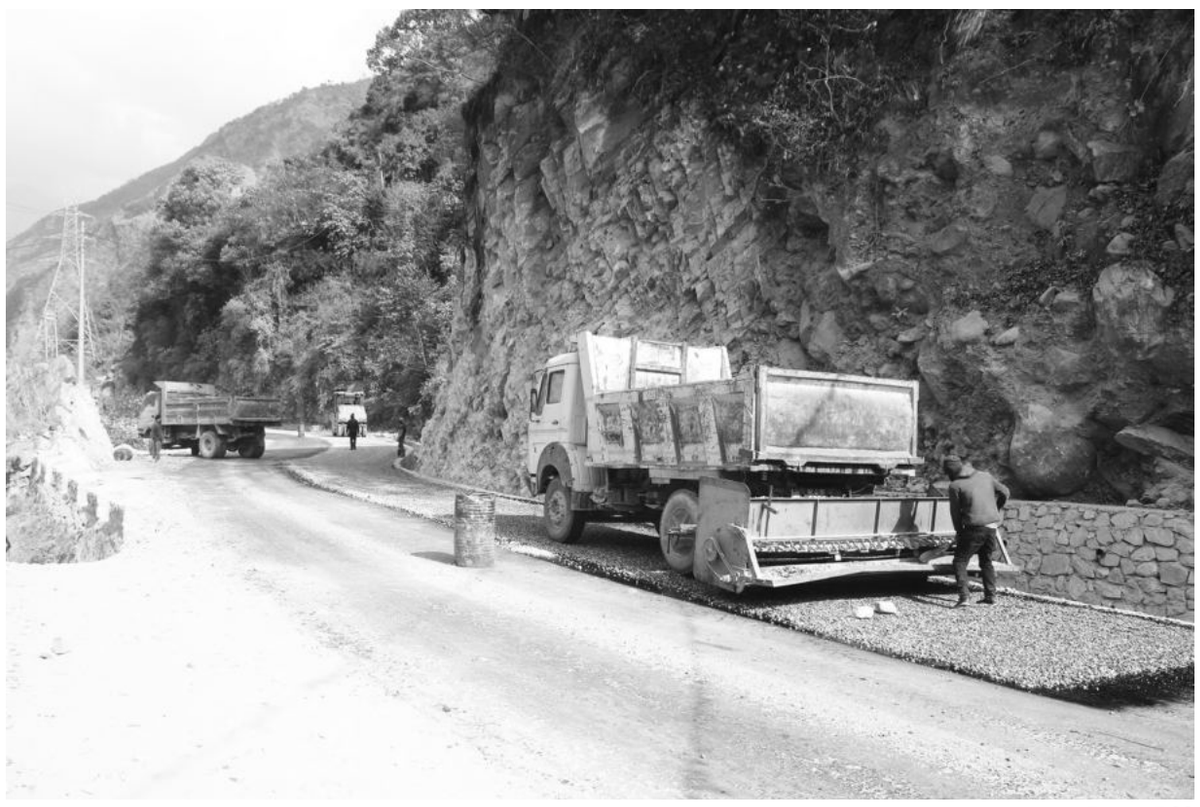


PHOTO: RSS

A road section of Kaligandaki Corridor under the Beni-Jomsom-Korala Road Project being blacktopped at Ratopani of Annapurna Rural Municipality in Myagdi district.

Martyrs week begins to remember heroes who gave life for freedom

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Martyr's Week began on Wednesday. On the first day of Martyr's Week, a memorial meeting was held at the place where Shukraraj Shastri attained martyrdom.

On the occasion, Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) Deputy Mayor Sunita Dangol and other officials paid a heartfelt tribute to martyr Shukraraj Shastri at Pachali in Teku, where Shastri was executed by the then Rana regime on January 23, 1941. Martyr Shastri's statue was garlanded.

Deputy Mayor Dangol briefed about the contribution of martyr Shastri and said that he was the first person to write the grammar of Nepal Bhasa. She said, "Martyr Shastri had always kept national sovereignty above personal and family interest. He got immortality fighting for it and because of his sacrifice people had been able to enjoy freedom and human rights."

She said that remembering martyrs for one day was not enough and there were many works left to honour such sacrifice.

A week-long programme is being organised under the coordination of the Kathmandu Metropolitan City in honour of the contribution of the martyrs who made sacrifices to bring about democracy in the country. During this, a commemorative meeting will be held on January 27 at Sifal, where martyr Dharmabhakta Mathema attained martyrdom and January 29 at Shobha Bhagwati, where martyrs Gangalal Shrestha and Dashrath Chand were executed.

These four martyrs – Shukraraj Shastri, Dharma Bhakta Mathema, Gangalal Shrestha and Dashrath Chand – had spearheaded the Revolution in 1941 to overthrow the 104-year-long autocratic family rule of the Ranas and establish democracy in the country.

The then prime minister Juddha Shumsher Rana had announced the death penalty for the four martyrs on January 19, 1941.

Four days later, Martyr Shastri was hanged from a tree at Teku, and Dharma Bhakta was hanged at Sifal ground after seven days.

Similarly, nine days after the death penalty was announced, Shrestha and Chand were shot dead on the banks of the Bishnumati River at Shobha Bhagwati.

Russia accuses Ukraine of shooting down plane

AP
Moscow, Jan. 24

Russia's Defense Ministry on Wednesday accused Ukrainian forces of shooting down a military transport plane, killing all 74 people aboard, including 65 Ukrainian prisoners of war being swapped.

Ukrainian officials did not immediately confirm or deny Russia's claims about the crash in Russia's Belgorod border region, although they said they were looking into them.

The Associated Press could not confirm who was aboard or other details on what brought the plane down. Throughout the 700-day war, Russia and Ukraine have traded conflicting accusations, and establishing the facts has often been difficult, both because of the constraints of a war zone and because each side tightly controls information.

Video of the crash posted on social media showed a plane falling from the sky in a snowy, rural area, and a massive ball of fire erupting where it apparently hit the ground.

In addition to the 65 POWs, the Il-76 transport carried a crew of six and three other passengers, the Russian military said. According to the statement, Russian radar registered the launch of two missiles from Ukraine's Kharkiv region that borders the Belgorod region. The ministry did not provide evidence for its claim.

Firefighters, ambulances and police rushed to the site in the Korochansky district of Belgorod, state news agency Tass reported, citing a local emergency services official.

The Russian military said the POWs were being flown to the region for a prisoner swap when the plane was downed at 11:15 a.m. local time (0815 GMT, 3:15 a.m. EST).

The Ukrainian military intelligence spokesman, Andrii Yusov, confirmed to media that a prisoner swap was to happen Wednesday but was not going ahead. He said the agency is checking whether Ukrainian POWs were on the plane.

The plane was headed to the Belgorod region from the Chkalovsky air field in the Moscow region, and the POW swap was scheduled to take place at the Kolotilovka crossing on the Russian-Ukrainian border, the statement read. The crossing is about 135 kilometers (85 miles) west of the village of Yablonovo, near where the plane fell.

Ukraine's Kharkiv region and Russia's Belgorod region have long been a focus of the fighting, especially involving airstrikes with missiles and drones.

Russia has largely ensured its air dominance during the war against Ukraine's fleet of Soviet-era warplanes. But Russia has suffered a series of crashes that some observers have attributed to a higher number of flights amid the fighting in Ukraine.

At the same time, Kyiv has boasted of shooting down two Russian command and control planes, which would be a major feat for Ukraine if true. Cross-border attacks on Russia's Belgorod region also have increased, with the deadliest one killing 25 people in December.

Shortly before the crash, Belgorod Gov. Vyacheslav Gladkov said on his Telegram channel that a "missile alert" had been triggered in the region and urged residents to take shelter.

Ukraine's Coordination Headquarters for the Treatment of Prisoners of War said it was looking into the crash but did not immediately provide any information.

Instead, it cautioned against sharing "unverified information."

"We emphasize that the enemy is actively conducting information special operations against Ukraine aimed at destabilizing Ukrainian society," it said in a statement on Telegram.

The Russian Defense Ministry said a special military commission was headed to the crash site.

Investment be made in productive sectors: FM Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24



Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has stressed the need for moving in the direction of getting more returns from limited resources citing that the economy has improved this year compared to last year.

Addressing the 59th anniversary function of the Rastriya Banijya Bank (RBB) on Wednesday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the banks and financial institutions should contribute more to economic development by investing in the productive sector.

Stating that there was a problem in the past due to large investments in unproductive sectors, he said that in the future, investments should be made only in the productive sectors.

"In the past, the investment from the bank did not go to the right place. A lot of credit was extended to the stock market and real estate business. The borrowers who took loans at that time are now in trouble. The interest rate has increased but there is no return," said the Minister of Finance, "Our needs are many. Resources are very limited. It is necessary to prioritise expenses. The resources of the state should be invested in the areas that give maximum returns."

He said that the government was working liberally for the improvement of the banking sector.

On the occasion, Governor of Nepal Rastra Bank Maha Prasad Adhikari said that the contribution of the RBB was significant to the economy.

He said that the country's economy was improving and the banks should focus on investing in the productive sector.

Dilip Kumar Dhungana, Chairman of the Board of Directors of the RBB, said that in the context of the growing competitive environment in the banking sector and rapidly changing customer expectations, the bank would address the expectations of all types of customers, from large entrepreneurs to small businessmen.

He said that the bank had been enhancing the quality of banking services and making them more reliable, safe, technological and customer-friendly.

Chief Executive Officer of the Bank Kiran Kumar Shrestha said that the bank had taken necessary steps to increase the overall productivity of the bank by making maximum use of all its resources

In order to provide quality service to the customers of the bank, it has been providing all the services and facilities as per the demand of the market, he said.

Besides, appropriate steps have been taken for the quality of credit, moral development of employees and sustainable professional development, he said.

Established 59 years ago in January, 1966, with the aim of supporting the development of the country's economic sector, RBB's customers has reached about 4.1 million.

The bank has been providing services through its 286 branches across the country. The bank has also made a significant leap in the field of digital banking.

Nation needs 92,000 additional health personnel: Minister Basnet

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Health and Population Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet highlighted the pressing need for 92,000 additional employees in the health sector during his address at the 50th-anniversary ceremony of Sukraraj Tropical and Infectious Disease Hospital on Wednesday.

Minister Basnet credited Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat for their supportive stance in the initiative to recruit 32,000 employees in the health sector. He expressed concern over the Ministry of Health's inability to increase the workforce since 1997, emphasizing that the scarcity of health workers has hindered the delivery of basic and quality services.

Attributing the migration of residents from villages because of the shortage of employment opportunities, Minister Basnet called for an end to the trend of people seeking medical treatment abroad for common ailments. He asserted that the government should not bear the cost of treatment for those who opt for overseas medical care when viable treatment options exist within Nepal.

Minister Basnet proudly declared Nepal's medical education as the best in South Asia, citing the increasing interest of foreign students to study in the country. He shared that the Minister of Health, Maldives, had expressed admiration for Nepal's medical education multiple times. In contrast, Minister Basnet compared the overwhelming demand for medical education in Nepal to India, where millions of applicants vie for a limited number of slots.

While advocating for the potential revenue from international students studying in Nepal, Minister Basnet acknowledged the increasing problem of migration, resulting in empty villages with only elderly residents and children. He emphasized the need to address the migration issue and expressed disappointment that leaders, whom he referred to as "those we call leaders," travel abroad for medical treatment, leaving the less fortunate without adequate healthcare support.

Similarly, Minister Basnet reiterated his commitment to enhancing Teku Hospital's capacity from 100 to 300 beds during his leadership.

Assuring that there will be a continuous stream of initiatives from the Ministry of Health to facilitate the expansion to 300 beds, Minister Basnet emphasized his determination to address the pressing need for healthcare professionals.

Expressing unwavering support for the hospital's development, Minister Basnet conveyed his dedication to contributing to the upliftment of Teku Hospital, ensuring that it will evolve to meet the growing healthcare demands.

UN chief warns that Israel's rejection of a two-state solution threatens global peace

AP
United Nations, Jan. 24

The United Nations chief warned Israel on Tuesday that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu 's rejection of a two-state solution will indefinitely prolong a conflict that is threatening global peace and emboldening extremists everywhere.

In his toughest language yet on the Israeli-Hamas war, Secretary-General Antonio Guterres told a ministerial meeting of the U.N. Security Council that "the right of the Palestinian people to build their own fully independent state must be recognized by all, and a refusal to accept the two-state solution by any party must be firmly rejected."

The alternative of a one-state solution "with such a large number of Palestinians inside without any real sense of freedom, rights and dignity … will be inconceivable," he said.



PHOTO: AP

United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres speaks on Tuesday, Jan. 23, 2024, at United Nations Headquarters.

Guterres also warned that the risks of regional escalation of the conflict "are now becoming a reality," pointing to Lebanon, Yemen, Syria, Iraq and Pakistan. He urged all parties "to step back from the brink and to consider the horrendous costs" of a wider war.

Netanyahu's rejection of a Palestinian state in any postwar scenario opened a wide rift with Israel's closest ally, the United States, which says the war must lead to negotiations for a two-state solution where Israel and the Palestinians can live side-by-side in peace. That goal is supported by countries around the world, as ministers and ambassadors reiterated Tuesday.

Uzra Zeya, the State Department's under secretary for civilian security, democracy and human rights, told the council, "A key component of U.S. diplomacy is to pursue a pathway both to a Palestinian state and normalization and integration between Israel and other regional states."

"The goal is a future where Gaza is never again used as a platform for terror, and a future where Palestinians have a state of their own," she said, reiterating the Biden administration's call on Israel to do more to protect Palestinian civilians.

Russia's Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov countered that American diplomacy "oscillates between vetoing resolutions about the ceasefire and at the same time calling for a reduction in the intensity of hostilities in Gaza."

"Without a doubt this serves as carte blanche for the ongoing collective punishment of Palestinians," Lavrov told the council.

Secretary-general Guterres repeated his longstanding call for a humanitarian cease-fire — an appeal with overwhelming global support.

Sculptors in Sagarhawa carving historical events on rocks



BY BHUWAN KARKI
Kapilvastu, Jan. 24

In the vicinity of Lambusagar Lake in Sagarhawa, in the archaeological site of Kapilvastu, a group of sculptors were diligently shaping lifeless stones into vibrant artworks.

Using iron tools on challenging rock surfaces, they endeavoured to convey a message of historical diversity, etching reminders of past events onto the enduring stones. Dineshwor Mahato, the head of the Sculpture Department at the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, enthusiastically participated in a 15-day sculpture workshop organised by the Lumbini Development Trust.

Reflecting on his experience, Mahato expressed joy in creating statues that vividly capture historical narratives.

Another sculptor, Sushmita Moktan, also shared her satisfaction after investing considerable effort in infusing the stones with artistic expressions.

During discussions with the media, Mahato delved into the historical and archaeological significance of Sagarhawa. This location is recognised as the site where, towards the end of Shakyamuni Buddha's life, the Sakyas faced a massacre orchestrated by King Virudhaka, the son of Prasenajita Raja of Kosala, seeking revenge.

Situated 9 km away from the Kapilvastu's district headquarters Taulihawa, 6 km north of Tilaurakot, and 7 km from Bangai on the East-West Highway, Sagarhawa also stands as the second bird reserve of Nepal, located south of Jagdishpur Lake. In the 7th century, Chinese pilgrim Huian Tsang mentioned in his travelogue the construction of numerous stupas on the west and south sides of Lake Sagarhawa in memory of the massacred Shakyas.

The first excavation in 1897 AD by Dr. Alois Anton Fuhrer revealed 17 large square stupas and numerous smaller stupas at Sagarhawa, containing materials like bone, gold, silver, crystal, and ruby. The area of Sagarhawa near Jagadishpur Lake spans in 52 bighas of land.

Seventeen idols depicting characters involved in the Shakyas massacre have been crafted during the 15-day workshop from January 8 to 22. Dhundiraj Bhattarai, treasurer of Lumbini Development Trust, shared that 15 sculptors, aided by 15 helpers, dedicated their efforts to crafting these statues.

Emphasising collaboration with the local community, Bhattarai highlighted the innovative approach taken to showcase the historical significance of the archaeological site and boost tourism.

Naradamani Hartmchhali, the Chancellor of Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, characterised the sculpture workshop in Kapilvastu as a comprehensive endeavour encompassing academic, cultural, technological and historical dimensions. He emphasised the need for establishing academic institutions at provincial and local levels to support such artistic and academic endeavours.

Sudip Paudel, the Mayor of Kapilvastu Municipality, said that the Trust's initiative in conducting the sculpture workshop was lauded.

Supported by various organisations, the sculpture workshop, as noted by Kapil Gyawali, Secretary-General of Lumbini Tourism Journalists Association, has not only engaged the local community but also generated excitement. Financial support for the sculptors' expenses was provided by the Lumbini Development Trust through the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, amounting to Rs.2.6 million.

Journalist Bhagishwor Limbu comes up with poetry collection



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

A poetry collection of journalist Bhagishwor Limbu was released on Tuesday in Basantpur of Laligurans Municipality in Tehrathum.

The collection consists of 35 poems composed in the Limbu language.

Urban Development Minister Sita Gurung released the collection.

During the release, Minister Gurung said that the local government should also support efforts to bring together various literary creators.

Poet Bhagishwor expressed his hope that his poetry collection would enhance the love for poetry among the latest generation of poets and literature enthusiasts interested in poetry.

Arjun Mabuhang, Mayor of Laligurans Municipality, emphasised the significance of publishing works by poet Bhagishwor, especially at a time when interest in language, script, art, literature, and culture was declining in the Limbu community.

Poet Limbu has been active in journalism for the past two decades, serves as the station manager of Radio Memchhyayem and is the former vice-president of the Federation of Nepal Journalists, Terhathum.

Loyang Sherpa wins World Rising Star

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24



Loyang Sherpa emerged winner in the 'World Rising Star 2024' a children's competition held in Georgia.

Loyang, a seventh-grader at Trijyoti Secondary School in Kapan, clinched the top title by surpassing contestants from 40 countries.

The song 'Resham Firiri' he sang in the talent round secured him the 'Talent Round' award in his category.

During the competition, Angel Babu Kattel received the 'Talent Award,' and Sanista Regmi was honoured with the 'Eurosia' Award. Following their participation, they returned to Kathmandu on Tuesday morning.

At Tribhuvan International Airport, Loyang expressed his happiness at winning the top title.

"I have graced the stage in numerous places, which is why I felt no fear standing on the stage in Georgia. I was confident that I would secure the top title," he remarked.

Adorned in traditional Sherpa attire during the cultural round Sherpa mentioned making many friends, inviting them to visit Nepal.

Prasun Jung Pokhrel, the winner of 'World Rising Star 2023,' attended the competition as a special guest, expressing joy at Nepal securing the top title once again.

Soniya GR, the head of Pariwartan Event House, which facilitated the contestants' journey to Georgia, expressed pride when the winner of the programme 'DSA Star' achieved the top category award in the international competition.

'Oppenheimer' dominates Oscar nominations, Gerwig passed over for best director

AP
New York, Jan. 24



After a tumultuous movie year marked by strikes and work stoppages, the Academy Awards showered nominations Tuesday on Christopher Nolan's blockbuster biopic, "Oppenheimer," which came away with a leading 13 nominations.

Nolan's three-hour opus, viewed as the best picture frontrunner, received nods for best picture and Nolan's direction; acting nominations for Cillian Murphy, Robert Downey Jr. and Emily Blunt; and multiple honors for the sweeping craft of the J. Robert Oppenheimer drama.

Though Nolan is regarded as the big-canvas auteur of his era, he's never won an Academy Award — nor have any of his films won best picture. This, though, could be his year. Reflecting on the rarity of his film's success — a lengthy drama dense with talk and the convulsions of history that nevertheless grossed nearly $1 billion — Nolan, in an interview Tuesday, called Oppenheimer "one of the great American stories."

The year's biggest hit, "Barbie," came away with a nominations haul slightly less than its partner in Barbenheimer mania.Greta Gerwig's feminist comedy, with more than $1.4 billion in ticket sales, was nominated for eight awards, including best picture; Ryan Gosling for best supporting actor; and two best song candidates in "What Was I Made For" and "I'm Just Ken."

Gerwig was surprisingly left out of the best director field. She was nominated for best director in 2018 for her solo directorial debut, "Lady Bird." At the time, Gerwig was just the fifth woman nominated for the award. Since then, Chloé Zhao ("Nomadland") and Jane Campion ("The Power of the Dog") have won best director. Before those wins, Kathryn Bigelow ("The Hurt Locker," in 2010) was the only woman to win the Oscar's top filmmaking honor.

Both Yorgos Lanthimos' Frankenstein riff "Poor Things" and Martin Scorsese's Osage epic "Killers of the Flower Moon" were also widely celebrated, with 11 and 10 nods apiece.

Lily Gladstone, star of "Killers of the Flower Moon," became the first Native American nominated for best actress. For the 10th time, Scorsese was nominated for best director. Leonardo DiCaprio, though, was left out of best actor. The late Robbie Robertson, who died in August, also became the first Indigenous person nominated for best score.

"Poor Things," a dark Victorian era fantasy about Bella Baxter's sexual awakening, received nominations for Lanthimos' direction, Emma Stone's leading performance, Mark Ruffalo's supporting performance and widespread nods for the old-school craft of its fantastical design.

The 10 films nominated for best picture were: "Oppenheimer," "Barbie," "Poor Things," "Killers of the Flower Moon," "The Holdovers," "Maestro," "American Fiction," "Past Lives," "Anatomy of a Fall" and "The Zone of Interest."

That group, which mirrored the Producers Guild Awards nominees, went much as expected and, as critics noted, a remarkably strong collection of films. For the first time, three of the best picture nominees were directed by women: "Past Lives" by Celine Song;"Anatomy of a Fall" by Justine Triet, also nominated for best director; and Gerwig's "Barbie."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Fear of judgment can overwhelm you without warning. Whether you're in front of a large number of friends or a small group of family, any crowd may cause anxiety.

CANCER: Jealousy could be rearing its head regarding a current partnership of yours. This person may be a close friend, but that won't stop envy from needling your heart if they receive something that you want.

LIBRA: Drama can be useful on occasion -- specifically, right now. There could be someone in your friend group or workplace who is making things difficult for you and even possibly other people.

CAPRICORN: Your pride may be hurt by someone that you weren't expecting. This person might be an elder or a supporter of yours who normally has positive things to say.

TAURUS: You might feel torn between family members or roommates. Loved ones may begin acting in controlling or dominating ways, and because of this, you're feeling torn in half.

LEO: Obsession with making a connection work could take over your day. While you want it to happen, the other person may not be as into it as you are, potentially leaving you frustrated.

SCORPIO: You may be more than a little obsessed with success right now. Because of your ambitious and focused attitude, you could accidentally steamroll the people in your way.

AQUARIUS: Envy isn't a great look on you, Aquarius. Someone you're interested in may appear to have the perfect life, perfect family, perfect career, all of that -- and you probably want a piece of it yourself.

GEMINI: Peer pressure may be leading you into a situation that you don't want to be in. You are possibly being asked to do something that you've never done before.

VIRGO: Fear can lead you to miss out on opportunities. You may know that someone else is competing for a promotion or an award, and because you are afraid of them or concerned about losing.

SAGITTARIUS: You might be worried about a trip that you're planning or taking. There are strong indicators that you're expanding your horizons in some way today.

PISCES: Well-meaning comments can still hurt at the moment. When you're too focused on someone or something, you may unintentionally neglect your other relationships, hobbies, or work.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal suffers 5-wicket loss to Pakistan



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN
Aakash Chand of Nepal bowling against Pakistan during ICC Men's U19 World Cup in East London, South Africa on Wednesday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Nepali young guns suffered a consecutive second loss after going down to Pakistan by five wickets in the ICC Men's U19 World Cup Cricket at the Buffalo Park Cricket Ground in East London, South Africa on Wednesday.

The second win steered Pakistan to the super six. Pakistan defeated Afghanistan in its opener. Nepal will next face Afghanistan on January 26 in its last group match. Both Nepal and Afghanistan are winless in the tournament. Nepal lost its opening match against New Zealand by 64 runs.

Electing to bat first, Nepal gave a medium target of 198 runs to Pakistan for victory. Pakistan in reply, achieved the victory with 201 on the scoreboard and 14 balls to spare. Pakistan came up with a solid start with openers duo Shamyl Hussain and Shahzaib Khan putting on an 81-run partnership for the first wicket. Medium pacer Aakash Chand succeed to put the brake on the partnership dismissing both on the 22nd over.

Azan Awais, however, cruised Pakistan to home with his not out half century knocks of 63. His patience batting included six boundaries off 82 balls.

Opener Hussain hit one six and four boundaries in his 59-ball 37 and Khan also added 37 off 70 deliveries that included three fours and one six before departing to dug out. Medium pacer Chand dismissed Arafa Minhas (8) for his third wicket and finished with a figure of 3-34.

The match winner Awais collaborated with Ahmad Hassan for 64 runs for the fifth wicket. Hassan clubbed four boundaries and added 37-ball 29 before being stumped by Bipin Rawal off Dipesh Kandel in 42.1 over. Haroon Arshad chipped in not out 15 runs off 18 deliveries. Dipesh Kandel and Aakash Tripathi also bagged one wicket apiece for Nepal.

Earlier, electing to bat first Nepal scored 197 runs for the loss of all wickets in the scheduled 50 overs. Bipin Rawal scored the highest 39 runs for Nepal. Rawal's batting included four fences and one six off 68 balls.

Similarly, Deepak Dumre chipped in with 26 runs while Captain Dev Khanal added 23 runs and Subas Bhandari garnered 20 runs for Nepal. Gulshan Jha (18), Akash Chand (16) and Dipesh Kandel (13) were other double-digit scorers for Nepal.

Pakistan's Arafat Minhas had three-wicket haul while Ahmed Hussain and Uwaid Shah took two wickets each to restrict Nepal for medium total.

In U-19 cricket, Nepal and Pakistan have competed twice before. In the meeting held in 2002, Nepal won by 30 runs. In the last encounter in 2016, Pakistan won by 122 runs. Nepal is pitted with New Zealand, Pakistan and Afghanistan in the Group D of U19 World Cup.

New Zealand, with four points after two wins, also moved to super six from Group D. The top three teams from each group moves to super six.

Nepal Police bags 5th win in a row

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 24

Nepal Police Club continued with its winning streak (five wins in five matches) on Day 12 of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament defeating Madhes Province by six wickets at Mulpani on Wednesday.

While Nepal Police has remained undefeated, Koshi Province failed to get a single win in the campaign as it lost its eighth group match against Sudur Pashchim Province in Kirtipur. Koshi will play its final match of the group stage against Lumbini in Kirtipur on January 30.

Including a win against title holders Nepal APF Club, Madhes has won its last three matches and was expected to upset Nepal Police. With the batting line-up showing quality games of late, Madhes looked happy to have been given to bat first. On the other hand, Nepal Police showed why it elected to field first against a good batting order of Madhes as two spinners shone with a joint nine wickets.

Sagar Dhakal took a fifer while Lalit Rajbanshi took four as they bundled out Madhes for 96 runs in 24 overs. Right-arm medium-pacer Rashid Khan took the remaining wicket for the Police.

Captain Harishankar Shah (22 off 33 balls), Araniko Yadav (23 off 26) and Abhishekh Tiwari (11 0ff 19) were the only batsmen for Madhes to score in double figures.

Despite posting a low total, Madhes still had the determination to win as Nepal Police openers entered the crease for the chase. Nepal Police had to lose four wickets to chase the target in the 19th over. Ranjit Kumar and Araniko took two wickets each for Madhes.

Amit Shrestha and Aarif Sheikh stayed not out at 15 and 16 runs respectively to win the fifth match for the team. Openers Sunil Dhamala and Kushal Bhurtel contributed 28 and 19 runs respectively.

Nepal Police is the table topper with 10 points in five matches.

On the other hand, Sudur Pashchim inflicted Koshi with its eighth consecutive loss in the tournament, defeating the eastern side by eight wickets.

With four batsmen scoring in double figures, Koshi was bowled out in 32 overs at 123 runs on the board. Sher Malla claimed a fifer while Bikash Aagri was a wicket short of his five-wicket haul. Sudur Pashchim chased the target in the 22nd over losing only the two openers – Khadak Bohora (9) and Captain Raju Rijal (21). Both fell victim to Koshi's Firdosh Ansari.

Naren Bhatta and debutant Prakash Pandey won the match for Sudur. Bhatta smacked a half-century in the win where Pandey played a second fiddle scoring 34 off 42 balls.

In the third match of the day, Tribhuwan Army Club clinched a 65-run win against Lumbini Province at the latter's home soil, Bhairahawa Cricket Ground in Rupandehi.

In a match reduced to 26 overs due to heavy fog in the Tarai region, Lumbini invited Army to bat first. Losing Santosh Karki, one of the openers, in the fourth over for 11 runs, another opener Imran Sheikh played for all 26 overs staying not out at 67 runs facing 70 deliveries.

Bhim Sharki added 24 runs while captain Binod Bhandari scored 34 off 25 helping Army post a target of 171 in the loss of seven wickets. Mohammad Hussain and Nar Sharki bagged two wickets for Lumbini.

In the chase, Lumbini played all 26 overs but fell short of 65 runs as they could only score 105 losing eight wickets. With four batsmen, including Sushant Thapa (wicketkeeper, opener batsman and captain), gone for a duck, only four players scored in double digits.

Krishna Karki was the highest scorer with 35 off 62 followed by Mrinal Gurung's, another opener, 18 off 24. Hussain, who took two wickets, also added 15 alongside Avishek Gautam's 11 off 23 to take Lumbini to 105.

Kushal Malla bagged four wickets while his national team colleague Sompal Kami bagged two. Avinash Karn and Shahab Alam also took one each for the Army.

Army has climbed to the third position in the table after the end of Day 12 with eight points.



PHOTO: BIKAS/TRN
Naren Bhatta of Sudurpaschim Province after scoring a half century against Koshi Province during Prime Minister Cup at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Wednesday.

SNIPPETS

Tamang named head coach

Kathmandu (TRN): The All Nepal Football Association (ANFA) has announced the appointment of Rajendra Tamang as the head coach of the National Women's team for the upcoming 2024 WAFF Women's Championship. The championship is scheduled to be held in Saudi Arabia from February 18 to 28. ANFA has also named Kamala Rakhal and Shyam Manandhar as assistant coaches and Brinda Dewan as the team manager. Ujwal Manandhar has been appointed as the Goalkeeping coach. After taking on the role of head coach, Tamang has already selected 40 players for the championship.

Army into quarterfinals

Pokhara (TRN): The Tribhuvan Army FC has advanced to the quarterfinals of the Aha Rara Pokhara Gold Cup tournament by defeating the Rising Star Football Club of Nawalparasi with a score of 1-0. Captain Bharat Khawas scored the only goal of the match by heading Dinesh Henjan's cross into the post in the 27th minute of the game, which was enough for the Army to secure their victory at the Pokhara Stadium on Wednesday. Despite being a first-time participant and not having any star players, Rising Star gave Army a tough challenge in the match. The Army will now face the defending champions, Sankata Club, in the quarterfinals on Sunday.

Local pro Sukra takes lead

Dharan (TRN): Nepal's top professional golfer Sukra Bahadur Rai scored an impressive 3-under 67 in the opening round of the Surya Nepal Eastern Open being held at the par-70 Dharan Golf Club. Sukra is currently leading the pack by one stroke, with Niraj Tamang close behind at 2-under 68. Amateur golfers Yubraj Bhujel and Padam Hang are in joint third place with a score of 1-under 69. Former top professional golfer Bhuvan Nagarkoti is in fifth place with an even-par score of 70. A total of 47 golfers, including 30 professionals and 17 amateurs, are participating in the 54-hole tournament, which has been organized by PGA Nepal and sponsored by Surya Nepal Pvt Ltd.

Yadav named T20I Cricketer of the Year

Dubai (ICC): India's explosive batter Suryakumar Yadav has won his second successive ICC Men's T20I Cricketer of the Year award, with West Indies' dynamic all-round captain Hayley Matthews claiming the ICC Women's T20I Cricketer of the Year as the International Cricket Council (ICC) announced first set of individual winners of the ICC Awards 2023 on Wednesday. New Zealand all-rounder Rachin Ravindra (ICC Emerging Men's Cricketer of the Year), Australia opener Phoebe Litchfield (ICC Emerging Women's Cricketer of the Year), Netherlands all-rounder Bas de Leede (ICC Men's Associate Cricketer of the Year) and Kenya captain Queentor Abel (ICC Women's Associate Cricketer of the Year) were the others celebrated on the first of two days dedicated to individual winners in the ICC Awards.

China's Zheng sets up Australian Open semis with Yastremska

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 24

Daniil Medvedev outlasted ninth-seeded Hubert Hurkacz 7-6 (4), 2-6, 6-3, 5-7, 6-4 on Wednesday to reach the semifinals of the Australian Open for the third time in four years.

In a grueling four-hour match containing numerous rallies of 20-plus shots, Medvedev held off a comeback attempt from Hurkacz to advance.

The women's semifinal lineup is complete after 12th-seeded Zheng Qinwen and Ukrainian qualifier Dayana Yastremska won their quarterfinals Wednesday to join 2023 champion Aryna Sabalenka and U.S. Open winner Coco Gauff in the last four.

Zheng and Yastremska have never gone so far in a major. They'll play Thursday for a spot in the final after Yastremska beat Linda Noskova 6-3, 6-4 in the day session and Zheng rallied to fend off Anna Kalinskaya 6-7 (4), 6-3, 6-1 at night.



Medvedev, who won the 2021 U.S. Open and is a two-time finalist in Australia, appeared on course for a more straight-forward victory when he led 4-2 in the fourth set but Hurkacz raised his game to take it to a decider.

Medvedev took the decisive break in the seventh game of the fifth and held on for victory, capped with a drop shot.

"I'm so destroyed right now," Medvedev, his hands clasped behind his head, said in his on-court interview. "I was feeling very tough physically in the send set already."

In the opening match on Day 11, No. 93-ranked Yastremska became only the second qualifier to reach the women's singles semis in Australia in the Open era, after Christine Storey in 1978.

"It's nice to make history because at that time I was not born," said Yastremska, who was born in 2000. "I'm super-happy, very tired."

In the night match, Zheng was down a set and 3-2 before winning 10 of the next 11 games to earn a spot in a Grand Slam semifinal for the first time. "Really excited. First time for me," Zheng said. "Really happy to be in the semifinals, especially with such a good performance like this."

Japan reaches Asian Cup last 16

AFP/AP
Doha, Jan. 24

Japan cruised into the last 16 of the Asian Cup and a possible showdown with South Korea after a 3-1 win over Indonesia on Wednesday. Ayase Ueda struck in each half to go with a late Indonesia own goal in Doha to send the pre-tournament favourites through as group runners-up behind Iraq.

Sandy Walsh scored a consolation goal for Indonesia in injury time at the end of the game. Japan will now face the winners of Group E -- South Korea's group. Jurgen Klinsmann's South Korea are currently second on goal difference behind Jordan and face Malaysia in their final group match on Thursday.



Indonesia finished third in Group D and will have to wait until the first round concludes on Thursday to see if they go through as one of the four best third-place teams.

The Palestinian soccer team and Syria advanced to the knockout stage of the Asian Cup for the first time on Tuesday. Both secured their place in the round of 16 as two of the best third-placed teams from the group stage. Oday Dabbagh scored twice for the Palestinian team in a 3-0 win over Hong Kong in Group C and Omar Khrbin struck the only goal in Syria's 1-0 win against India in Group B.

Australia advanced as the Group B winner after a 1-1 draw with Uzbekistan.

The 2015 champion had already secured a place in the round of 16 after two straight wins and confirmed the group win after picking up a point at Al Janoub Stadium.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:38 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly to generally cloudy in Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly regions of the country and Partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	14.2	1.0	0.0
Dipayal	21.8	1.9	0.0
Dhangadi	15.6	5.5	0.0
Birendranagar	21.5	2.7	0.0
Nepalgunj	13.9	5.0	0.0
Jumla	11.6	-4.3	0.0
Ghorahi	20.2	5.0	0.0
Pokhara	19.0	7.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	12.8	5.7	0.0
Simara	12.2	7.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.2	3.5	Traces
Okhaldhunga	14.4	5.2	0.0
Taplejung	14.1	3.6	0.0
Dhankuta	21.0	6.2	0.0
Biratnagar	17.9	9.5	0.0
Jomsom	6.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	22.0	9.4	0.0*
Lumle	14.6	3.6	0.0*
Janakpur	14.8	9.5	0.0*
Jiri	12.3	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 25, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.70	Rs. 133.30
Euro	1	Rs. 144.60	Rs. 145.26
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.14	Rs. 169.90
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.53	Rs. 154.23
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.58	Rs. 87.97
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.68	Rs. 99.13
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.17	Rs. 99.62
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.00	Rs. 9.04
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.53	Rs. 18.62
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.74
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.05	Rs. 28.17
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.72	Rs. 12.77
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.39	Rs. 19.48
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.97	Rs. 17.05
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.36	Rs. 433.31
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.01	Rs. 353.60

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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